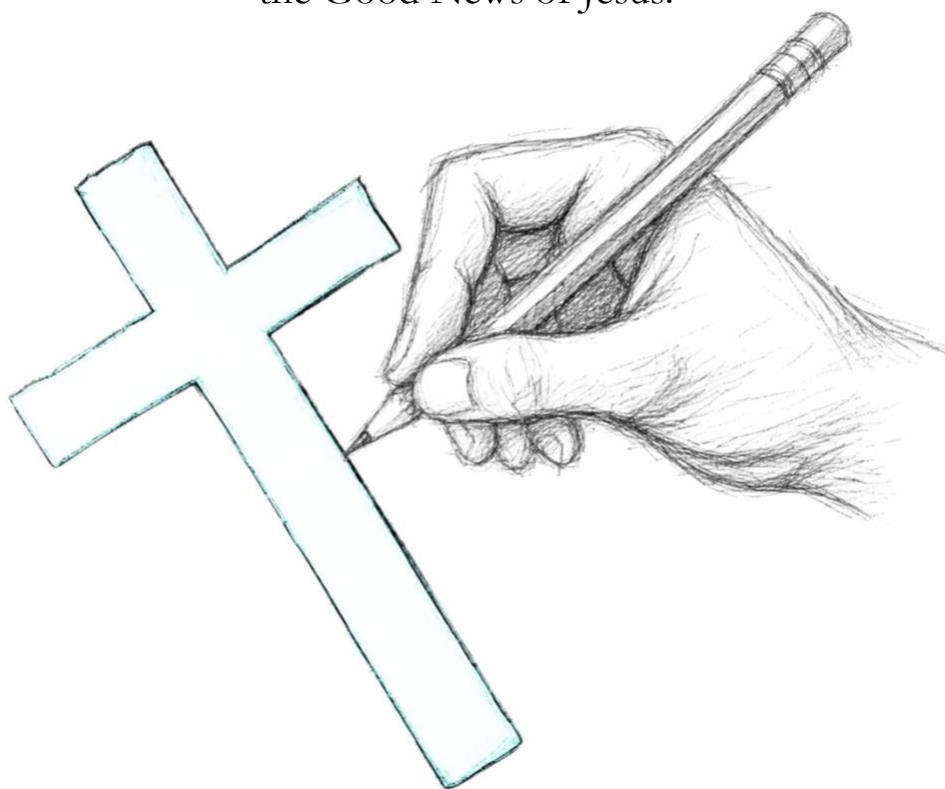


THE VISUAL GOSPEL

A 30-Day Devotional Exploring
the Good News of Jesus.



PHILIP LEINEWEBER

The Visual Gospel

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First Edition

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DEDICATION

To my Sarah, thank you for displaying the beauty of the gospel in your unconditional, covenant love for me through the years.

To Mom and Dad, thank you for giving me gospel clarity at a very young age.
The greatest gift you ever gave me was Jesus!

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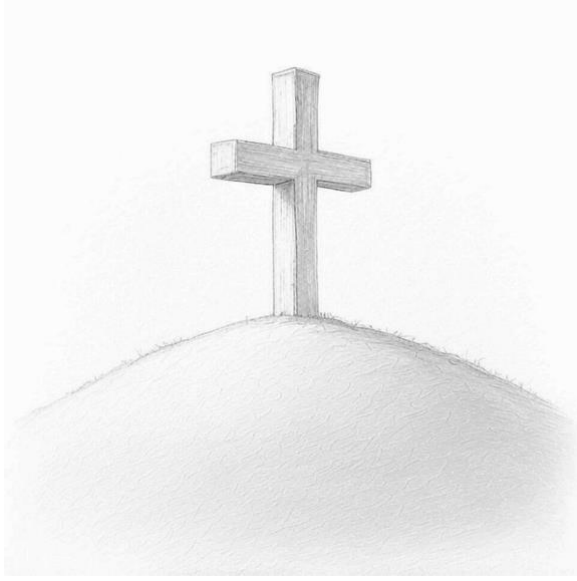
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INTRODUCTION

“So that Christ may dwell in your hearts through faith—that you, being rooted and grounded in love, may have strength to comprehend with all the saints what is the breadth and length and height and depth, and to know the love of Christ that surpasses knowledge, that you may be filled with all the fullness of God.”

Ephesians 3:17-19

It is often said that “a picture is worth a thousand words.” There is something powerful and memorable about what we see.

We live in an image-saturated culture. Businesses, churches, and influencers emphasize a brand and post on social media, and almost everyone walks around with a screen in the palm of their hand. We are surrounded by pictures. As visual creatures, what we see affects us.

There is nothing more beautiful in all of human history than the gospel of Jesus Christ. The gospel means “good news.” The good news of who Jesus is and what He has done. We will explore the gospel by looking at theological words which reveal different aspects of what Jesus did on the cross and why.

In *The Visual Gospel*, we employ pictures to present the unchanging gospel story in a visual way. These images are meant to make the theological more tangible and memorable so that we can see and savor Jesus more.

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*“That which was from the beginning, which we have heard,
which we have seen with our eyes, which we looked upon and
have touched with our hands, concerning the word of life...”
(1 John 1:1)*

My hope for us in these following pages is that we would see the glory of Jesus and love Him more. The cross reveals God’s great love for us. The gospel is good news because it declares the love of God for His people and invites us to be reconciled to our Maker. Understanding how Jesus was crucified and raised from the dead awakens love and cultivates joy, peace, and worship.

The gospel resembles a perfect diamond. Each facet of the diamond reflects and refracts light to dazzle our eyes. The following rich theological terms represent the facets of the gospel diamond. Each facet in its own way helps us see the beauty of the light of the gospel of Jesus Christ in its own way. They help us understand who God is, the problem we face, what He has done in the cross, and so much more. These words, such as condemnation, propitiation, atonement, or mediation, when better understood shine “the light of the gospel of the glory of Christ” (2 Corinthians 4:4). When we look at Jesus through these different facets of the gospel diamond, the beauty of the cross is magnified. My hope is that by tying each of these “gospel words” to a simple picture, we can better understand and see and then more readily recall the wonder of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ and His gospel. As the old hymnist, Isaac Watts, proclaims,

*When I survey the wondrous cross
on which the Prince of glory died,
my richest gain I count but loss,
and pour contempt on all my pride.*

*Forbid it, Lord, that I should boast
save in the death of Christ, my God!
All the vain things that charm me most,
I sacrifice them through his blood.*

*See, from his head, his hands, his feet,
sorrow and love flow mingled down.
Did e’er such love and sorrow meet,
or thorns compose so rich a crown?*

*Were the whole realm of nature mine,
that were a present far too small.
Love so amazing, so divine,
demands my soul, my life, my all.*

“When I Survey the Wondrous Cross”
—Isaac Watts*

How to use this devotional:

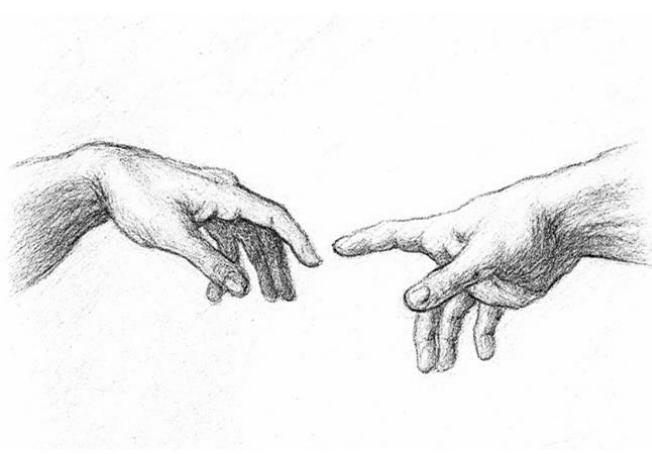
The Visual Gospel is designed to be read one day at a time as a means of devotional and worshipful reflection on the work of Christ. Take your time and meditate on the Scriptures in each entry. Use the Reflection Questions to think about how each gospel word relates to your life or as a tool for discussion in a family or small group setting. Intentionally follow the Gospel Response to remind yourself throughout the day of what you have learned. Finally, use the Prayer to prompt you to abide in Christ and help the truths to move from your head and to your heart.

**All songs and books/authors referenced throughout the devotional can be found on page 134 in the back of the book.*

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PART I
GOD'S HEART
Who is this God and what is He like?

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DAY 1

CREATION

“Then God said, ‘Let us make man in our image, after our likeness. And let them have dominion over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the heavens and over the livestock and over all the earth and over every creeping thing that creeps on the earth.’ So God created man in his own image, in the image of God he created him; male and female he created them.”

Genesis 1:26-27

Hebrew: עָשָׂה (*asah*) – “to fashion, accomplish, or produce”

Greek: ποιεῖν (*poieō*) – “to make, to create, to do”

The gospel starts in the garden. The good news begins with a good God creating a good world. Creation demonstrates that God is all-powerful and in control. He is the Ruler of all. He is sovereign over all creation. There is no creation without a Creator. We must emphasize this because we often make ourselves the center of the gospel when the gospel primarily reveals to us who our Creator is. This is God’s story and the gospel reveals that He is good.

After God created the heavens and the earth (Genesis 1:1), He reached down and made something entirely different. Humanity, man and woman, were made by God in His image for His glory. Adam and Eve were made to walk in perfect relationship and fellowship with God apart from sin, separation, or shame. Humanity was created to carry His image in all of creation, as the Westminster Shorter Catechism says, “to glorify God and enjoy Him forever.”

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The prophet Isaiah expounds on this purpose:

*“Bring my sons from afar
and my daughters from the end of the earth,
everyone who is called by my name,
whom I created for my glory,
whom I formed and made.” (Isaiah 43:6-7)*

We were made to know God, love Him, and enjoy Him forever. You are God’s handiwork. And God called man and woman, “very good” (Genesis 1:31). No other part of creation was made in the image and likeness of God (Genesis 1:26-27). *You* were made for God. In fact, everything was created for God.

“All things were created through Him and for Him.” (Colossians 1:16)

Fulfillment in this life will never be found apart from fellowship with our Maker. As Augustine wrote, “You have made us, oh God, and our hearts are forever without rest til they find their rest in you.” It is only through being connected to the Vine, communing with our Creator, that we can have abundant life and the fullness of joy (See Psalm 16:11; 100:3; John 10:10; 15:11).

Sadly, not long after being made, man chose to disobey God and fracture this perfect fellowship with their Maker. They were removed from the garden and their natures and all of creation were corrupted by sin and death. This is why the gospel is so important. The gospel is the story of God’s rescue and redemption of man. It is how God intends to restore Eden through the second Adam, Jesus Christ. This saving seed of the woman was promised as God cursed the serpent,

“I will put enmity between you and the woman, and between your offspring and her offspring; he shall bruise your head, and you shall bruise his heel.” (Genesis 3:15)

Jesus, the seed, would undo sin and crush the serpent’s head, but it would cost something. The author of Hebrews reflecting on the Savior writes, “In these last days he has spoken to us by his Son, whom he appointed the heir of all things, through whom also he created the world” (Hebrews 1:2, See also Acts 17:24-26). Jesus, the Son of God and Creator of the world, came into it as a man to redeem it by taking our place (John 1:1-14). The New Testament word, “created,” is used to describe Jesus being “made” sin for us by the Apostle Paul in 2 Corinthians.

*For our sake he **made** him to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him
we might become the righteousness of God. (2 Corinthians 5:21)*

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This is not to say that Jesus was created, He was the “Word” through whom “all things were made” (John 1:3). But when sin separated humanity from its Creator, Jesus defeated it by becoming our sin and nailing it to the cross. The image of God and our relationship with Him is restored through Jesus who can make us a righteous new creation (2 Corinthians 5:17; Ephesians 2:10; Revelation 21:5). Jesus came to redeem His creation, to remake what was broken. You were made for a right relationship with God. The gospel is the good news that we can be remade. You can become a new creation through Jesus.

This same word for “create” or “make” is also found at the end of the story. After Jesus returns, the paradise that was lost, the garden from which we were removed, will be remade. We will forever be with Him again, completely freed from the brokenness of this world.

*“And he who was seated on the throne said, “Behold, I am **making** all things new.” Also he said, “Write this down, for these words are trustworthy and true.” (Revelation 21:5)*

Definition

Creation is God making the whole world and everything in it. He made people in a special way so we could know, love, and reflect Him.

Reflection Questions

Reflect on the Augustine quote, “You have made us, O God, and our hearts are forever without rest till they find their rest in you.” How has this idea rung true in your life and experience?

Why does the gospel begin in the garden? What were we, as God’s image and likeness, made for?

Gospel Response

When you see beauty in the natural world, pause and thank God for His beautiful creation. Remember that you are His most prized handiwork, made in His image for relationship with Him.

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Prayer

Creator God,

Thank you for making me. I worship you as the almighty Creator of heaven and earth.

Awaken me to the reality that I was made for you, to glorify, know, and enjoy you forever.

Thank you for undoing what the fall and sin did through Jesus. Open my eyes to the gospel of Jesus Christ, the Redeemer of the world.

Amen.



DAY 2

LOVE

“For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him should not perish but have eternal life.”

John 3:16

Greek: ἀγάπη (*agapē*) – “to love, delight in, or be well-pleased with”

There is no word more at the heart of the gospel than “love.” If the gospel is the good news of Jesus, what He has done for us, then love is *who* He is and *why* He did it. At the heart of God’s redemption of us is His love for us.

*“But God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners,
Christ died for us.” (Romans 5:8)*

This is the *why* of the gospel. “For God so loved the world that he gave” are rightly some of the most popular words in Christianity. God’s love motivates His redemption. Even when we were sinful and depraved, God, because of His unconditional love, made a way for us to be reconciled to Himself. How great must this love be that it would motivate God the Father to offer His one and only Son on the cross for us?

What a miracle it is that though we were dead in our trespasses and sin,

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“God, being rich in mercy, because of the great love with which he loved us” offers us life through Jesus (Ephesians 2:4). His love for us is greater than we can possibly imagine. Who can even fathom it? Paul prays that the Christians at Ephesus would see and understand the depths of this love,

“That you...may have strength to comprehend with all the saints what is the breadth and length and height and depth, and to know the love of Christ that surpasses knowledge, that you may be filled with all the fullness of God.” (Ephesians 3:17-19)

There is no doubt that God desires that we delight in His love. His will in the gospel of Jesus Christ was for us to see, savor, and respond to His love. For “in this the love of God was made manifest among us...he loved us and sent his Son to be the propitiation for our sins” (1 John 4:9-10). The cross is the greatest example of love in history. That the Father would send His Son to die for sinners should astound us. How much must He love us? As Scripture states, “greater love has no one than this, that someone lay down his life for his friends” (John 15:13).

The parable of the lost son illustrates this love God has for us in the unconditional love of a father. After disowning his father and taking his inheritance early and squandering it, the son returns in shame, happy to be a slave in his father’s house. This is the father’s response:

And he arose and came to his father. But while he was still a long way off, his father saw him and felt compassion, and ran and embraced him and kissed him. (Luke 15:20)

This is how our heavenly Father lavishes His love on those who come to Him in faith. This is a picture of an unconditional and generous love. This love drove Christ to the cross. This love led the Father to forsake the Son. This love is ours in Christ Jesus. And nothing can separate us from it (Romans 8:38-39). How great is the love of God!?

*The love of God is greater far
than tongue or pen can ever tell;
it goes beyond the highest star,
and reaches to the lowest hell;
the guilty pair, bowed down with care,
God gave His Son to win;
His erring child He reconciled,
and pardoned from his sin.*

*Refrain:
O love of God, how rich and pure!
How measureless and strong!
It shall forevermore endure:*

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the saints' and angels' song!

*Could we with ink the ocean fill
and were the skies of parchment made,
were ev'ry stalk on earth a quill
and ev'ry man a scribe by trade,
to write the love of God above
would drain the ocean dry;
nor could the scroll contain the whole,
tho' stretched from sky to sky*

“The Love of God.”
—Frederick M. Lehman,

Definition

Love is God choosing to give of Himself for our good. It is God’s faithful commitment to rescue and restore. It is seen most clearly in God sending His Son, Jesus, to save sinners.

Reflection Questions

What comes to your mind when you think about love?

Read John 15:13. Reflect on how Jesus shows His love for us. How should this make us feel? How should this shape our hearts?

Gospel Response

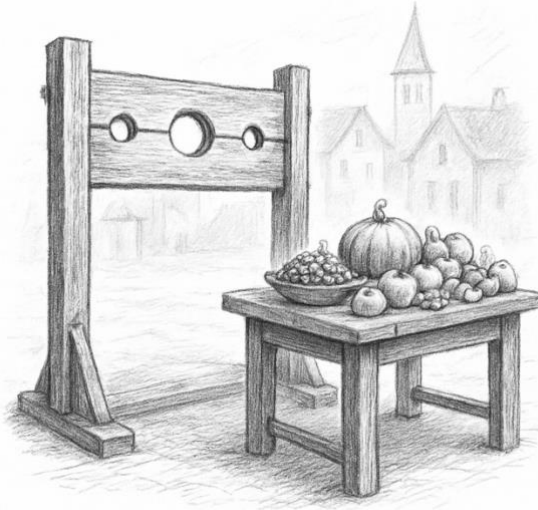
If you see a parent with their child today think of the unconditional love that parents have for their children. Think about how loving parents willingly sacrifice themselves for the sake of their kids and how God has this same kind of love for us.

Prayer

Loving Father,

I praise you that you are loving. Thank you for demonstrating your love for me through Jesus. When I feel unwanted or unloved may I remember your great love for me. Thank you for adopting me into you family. Help me to see what kind of love the Father has given to me, that I should be called a child of God; and so I am (1 John 3:1).

Amen



DAY 3

MERCY

“Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead,”

1 Peter 1:3

Greek: *ελεος (eleos)* – “mercy, kindness or good will”

In times past, it was not uncommon to be placed in stocks, wooden restraints that would immobilize a person in the town square for criminal offenses. This public humiliation might include throwing rotten food or mud to shame the guilty party. Can you imagine the embarrassment?

This should have been us. Far worse, we deserved the gallows or the guillotine, eternal hell and the condemnation of God for our sin. But God.

“But God, being rich in mercy...” (Ephesians 2:4)

In God’s mercy, he not only releases us from the penalty of our sin but he treats us with kindness and compassion instead! The fruit that should have been thrown is now sitting on the table for us to enjoy. His mercy is *greater* than all our sin. It is not just sufficient to release us from our sin but His mercy

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unleashes His compassion, love, and grace in our lives. We are not just freed from the stocks; we are invited to the table.

Many have said that mercy is “not getting what I deserve,” and this is true, but God’s mercy is far greater than that. God’s mercy does not just move us to neutral territory; it invites us into a restored relationship. It flows out of His love and kindness for us.

“The steadfast love of the Lord never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness.” (Lamentations 3:22-23)

Mercy is who God is and how He pursues His people. It is a never-ending fountain for those who fear Him (Luke 1:50). When Moses asked God, “Show me your glory” God reveals His mercy. As He passed before Moses, God said, “the LORD, the LORD, a God **merciful** and gracious...” (Exodus 34:6; see also Nehemiah 9:17; Psalm 86:15; 103:8; 145:8; Joel 2:13).

The Psalmist praises God for His glorious mercy, “He does not deal with us according to our sins... For as high as the heavens are above the earth, so great is His mercy...” (Psalm 103:10–11). And God’s mercy is what drove Him to send Jesus to the cross to save us, forgive us, and give us new life. It is “according to His great mercy, He has caused us to be born again to a living hope” (1 Peter 1:3). Furthermore, “He saved us, not because of works...but according to His own mercy” (Titus 3:5). From what did God save us? As we will see in the days to come, we deserved God’s wrath, judgment, and condemnation for our sin. John Stott says it perfectly,

“It is mercy which moved God to send His Son, for at the cross justice and mercy meet. Mercy does not eliminate God’s holiness, but expresses His heart to save.”

We deserved the stocks, but when we respond to Jesus in faith, we receive His unending mercy. We were criminals who were freed. We were homeless but now invited into a palace. We were starving but now fed. We were thirsty but given living water and all because God is rich in mercy. Mercy has triumphed over judgment (James 2:13). Let us sing of the wonderful mercy of God!

*Come, thou Fount of every blessing;
tune my heart to sing thy grace;
streams of mercy, never ceasing,
call for songs of loudest praise.
Teach me some melodious sonnet,
sung by flaming tongues above;
praise the mount! I’m fixed upon it,
mount of God’s unchanging love!*

“Come, Thou Fount of Every Blessing” —Robert Robinson

Definition

Mercy is God's compassionate withholding of deserved judgment and His tender action toward helpless sinners. It is God's desire to relieve the consequences of sin in those who deserve condemnation through Christ's sacrifice.

Reflection Questions

Have you ever received radical mercy? How did this feel?

Why is understanding the holiness, justice, and judgment of God essential to really seeing the beauty of God's mercy?

Gospel Response

Look for a piece of fruit today and think about how you deserved punishment and shame, rotten fruit thrown in your face in the public square. But then you received mercy. Give thanks to God for this wonderful gift.

Prayer

Merciful God,

Thank you for the good news of mercy. Help me to remember today that because of Jesus I have it far better than I deserve. Strengthen me to extend this same mercy to others in my life who may sin against me.

Amen



DAY 4

GRACE

“For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast.”

Ephesians 2:8-9

Greek: χάρις (*charis*) – “grace, good will, lovingkindness, favor”

Have you ever been hungry to the point of pain and weakness? My family loves watching the CBS show *Survivor*. One of the challenges for the contestants who are left on a deserted island is the lack of food. Weakness and exhaustion set in and heighten the drama! Sadly, our entertainment is the reality for millions of people around the world, where hunger is just a state of existence. Imagine living like this. Picture yourself starving and without hope of finding food in and of yourself. This was our condition before Jesus: complete and utter need. We had no food. We were starving to death. Then Jesus invites us to the table and gives us a feast. Grace met us in our sin.

“For if many died through one man’s trespass, much more have the grace of God and the free gift by the grace of that one man Jesus Christ abounded for many.” (Romans 5:15)

This word for grace, *charis*, is used over 150 times in the New Testament. It represents a gift, unmerited favor, and the abounding lovingkindness of a good God who freely gives salvation to His children out of His love and mercy. It is

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unearned. It is a free gift of God in Jesus and “if it is by grace, it is no longer on the basis of works; otherwise, grace would no longer be grace” (Romans 11:6).

When Moses asked God, “Show me your glory” God reveals Himself as gracious. As he passed before Moses, God said, “the LORD, the LORD, a God merciful and **gracious**...” (Exodus 34:6). God is a gracious God. He glories in demonstrating His grace to an undeserving and needy people, to a people who have fallen short.

“All have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified by His grace as a gift...” (Romans 3:23–24)

This gift totally meets our needs. It is sufficient for us and is made perfect in our weakness (2 Corinthians 12:9). And it is only through God’s grace that we can receive forgiveness by faith (Ephesians 2:8-9). We did not pay the bill, God did. Grace means God said: “this one is on Me.” It is free to us, but the cost of grace was certainly not free.

“For you know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that though he was rich, yet for your sake he became poor, so that you by his poverty might become rich.” (2 Corinthians 8:9)

Jesus emptied Himself, humbled Himself, to the point of death on the cross to offer this free gift to those who would believe in Him. God the Father plundered the heart of heaven, sending His only Son, to give us grace. This grace, in Jesus, “has appeared, bringing salvation for all people...” (Titus 2:11-12). Jesus, the Holy Son of God, is the perfect picture of God’s grace. “We have seen His glory...full of grace and truth” (John 1:14). J.I. Packer describes the glory of God’s grace beautifully in his timeless classic *Knowing God*,

“Grace is God’s love in action toward people who deserve the opposite of love. Grace is God moving heaven and earth to save sinners who could not lift a finger to save themselves.”

The gospel, the good news of Jesus, displays God’s amazing grace. A grace that conquers all our sin, “where sin increased, grace abounded all the more...” (Romans 5:20–21). God’s grace authored this redemption mission of grace before time began. For it was God who saves “us and called us to a holy calling, not because of our works but because of his own purpose and grace, which he gave us in Christ Jesus before the ages began” (2 Timothy 1:9). Displaying His amazing grace through Jesus to give us the free gift of salvation has always been the plan, “to the praise of his glorious grace, with which he has blessed us” (Ephesians 1:9). Thank God for His amazing, undeserved grace!

*Amazing grace! how sweet the sound,
That saved a wretch; like me!*

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*I once was lost, but now am found,
Was blind, but now I see*

“Amazing Grace”
—John Newton

Definition

Grace is God’s unmerited favor freely given to sinners who deserve judgment, granting them salvation, forgiveness, and every spiritual blessing through Jesus Christ. It is not earned, deserved, or repaid; it flows from God’s sovereign goodness and love.

Reflection Questions

What was the best gift you have ever received? What made it so meaningful?

When was the first time you understood God’s grace? Are you still walking in the same thankfulness for it today?

Gospel Response

Find something in your life that was given to you as a gift. Think about how the gospel is completely a work of God’s grace, it is a gift. It is not something deserved or earned but an unmerited kindness from your Creator.

Prayer

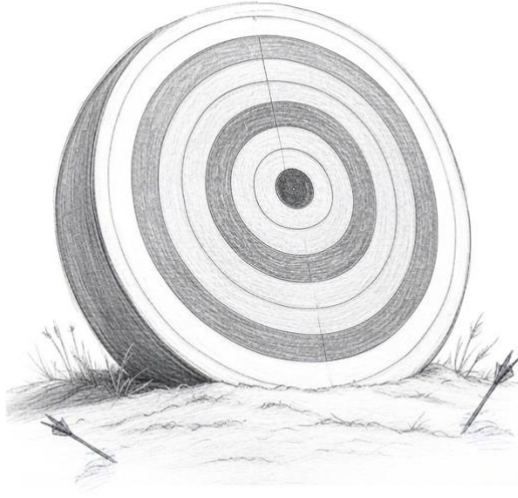
Gracious God,

Your grace is more than enough for me. Thank you for pouring your grace upon me time and time again. Thank you for sending Jesus, the expression of your grace. Help me to see every blessing in my life as a work of your grace.

Amen

PART II
OUR PROBLEM

What went wrong and why we need the gospel.



DAY 5

SIN

“For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God.”
Romans 3:23

Greek: ἁμαρτία (*hamartia*) – “to miss the mark, trespass, err”

The beauty and harmony of God's creation lasted a full two chapters of the Bible. Then, something went terribly wrong. Herein lies the need for the gospel and the necessity of His unconditional love, mercy, and grace. Simply put, when it comes to the gospel, there is no good news without bad news first.

“Until sin be bitter, Christ will not be sweet.”
—Thomas Watson

Too often we think of our sin as simply a mistake, merely an “oops.” We minimize our unrighteousness and the severity of it. In reality, sin is any failure to conform to the moral law of God in act, attitude, or nature, whether by doing what God forbids or failing to do what He commands.

Apart from Christ, it is not just *what* we do; it is *who* we are. We do sin and we are sinners. Our identity as humans is tainted by our sinfulness. Paul writes, “by the one man's disobedience the many were made sinners” (Romans 5:19). This is who we are before we meet Jesus. Can you honestly admit this reality: “I am a sinner in need of a Savior.”

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The gospel can have no effect until we confess our sinfulness. Sadly, our sin goes far deeper than most of us would like to admit. It strikes right to the core of every person.

Sin is universal; all human beings are sinners by nature and by choice (Romans 5:12). It is total, sin affects every part of the person: mind, will, body, emotions, and desires. Sin is rebellion, not just weakness; it is active defiance against a holy God. Sin is relational, it breaks fellowship with God and can seriously harm others as well (Isaiah 59:2; Psalm 51:4). Finally, sin is deserving of judgment, it earns spiritual death and divine wrath (Romans 6:23; Ephesians 2:3). Without God, even our attempts at righteousness fall short. They miss the mark.

*“We have all become like one who is unclean,
and all our righteous deeds are like a polluted garment.
We all fade like a leaf, and our iniquities,
like the wind, take us away.” (Isaiah 64:6)*

The reality is we have all missed the mark. **We are the arrow that missed the target.** Our nature falls short. David wrote, “Behold, I was brought forth in iniquity, and in sin did my mother conceive me” (Psalm 51:5). As descendants of Adam, the first sinner, we were brought into existence as an arrow shot in the wrong direction. Our very nature, our identity, was sinner. There is not one part of all of creation that was unaffected by the fall. That is not infected with this problem of sin.

We miss the mark daily. We constantly sin through active thoughts, words, and deeds that violate the character of God, the target. Our arrows fall short (Romans 3:23). So much so, that the Apostle John states that “if we say we have no sin, we deceive ourselves, and the truth is not in us” (1 John 1:8). One of the first marks of someone who has come to know Jesus is their awareness of their own sinfulness.

Even more than that, we miss the mark by failing to shoot arrows that we should. Actions that miss the mark are sins of commission, actions we fail to do, arrows we fail to shoot, are sins of omission. God’s Word says, “so whoever knows the right thing to do and fails to do it, for him it is sin” (James 4:17). We are sinners not just because we miss the shot, but we daily refuse to take the right shots.

If sin weren’t so serious, if our sinfulness were not so tragic, the cross wouldn’t be necessary. Thankfully, where we missed the mark, Jesus hits the bullseye. Where the first Adam failed, the Second Adam triumphed.

*“You know that he appeared in order to take away sins, and in him there is no sin.”
(1John 3:5)*

Definition

Sin is any failure to conform to the moral law of God in act, attitude, or nature, whether by doing what God forbids or failing to do what He commands.

Reflection Questions

Think about when you were a young child. What were some of your first experiences of guilt and shame for your sinfulness?

How can guilt and shame be a mercy from God that can point us to our need for Jesus? (See Romans 2:15)

How does God respond to those who come to Him with an attitude of self-righteousness instead of remorse for their sin? (See Luke 18:9-14)

Gospel Response

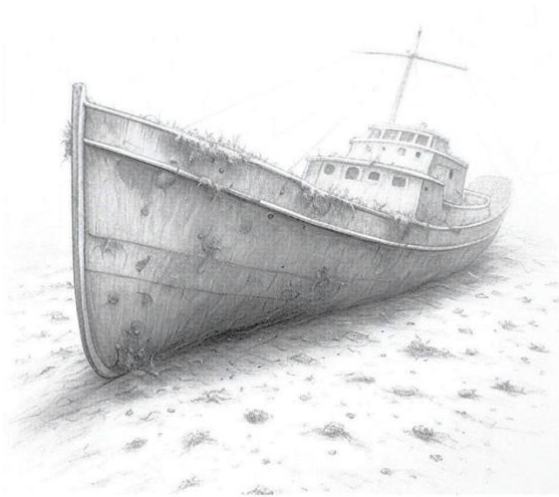
Read 1 John 1:7-10. Spend some time intentionally confessing wrongful thoughts, attitudes, words and actions. Trust God's promise that when we confess our sin He forgives and cleanses.

Prayer

Father God,

Have mercy on me, a sinner. Make me more aware of the darkness in my heart and my own sinfulness. Bring a godly sorrow that leads to repentance in my life. Forgive me for my sinful acts, attitudes, and thoughts. Forgive me for minimizing my sin, as if it is not that big of a deal. Thank you that you came to save me from my sin.

Amen



DAY 6

DEPRAVITY

*“And you were dead in the trespasses and sins in which you once walked”
Ephesians 2:1-2*

Greek: νεκρός (*nekros*) – “dead, lifeless, without life or power”

On April 15th, 1912 the Titanic struck an iceberg on its maiden voyage across the Atlantic and sank over 12,000 feet to the bottom of the ocean. Imagine over 50,000 tons sitting on the ocean floor. It is dead in the water. At the time one of mankind’s marvels, now sitting for generations at the bottom of the sea. The sunken ship illustrates the state of our soul before we have been raised to new life by Jesus. We were dead in our sin. Every part of our nature (mind, will, emotions, body) is corrupted, and no one naturally seeks God or is capable of making progress without God’s intervention.

*“None is righteous, no, not one; no one understands; no one seeks for God. All have turned aside; together they have become worthless; no one does good, not even one.”
(Romans 3:10-12)*

This does not mean that everyone is as bad as they *could* be. But it does mean that every single fiber of one’s being is tainted by sin. Depravity describes the condition of our nature. It is who we are before Jesus. We are spiritually dead. We are sunken ships.

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This sinful state has deeply affected us to our very core. Wickedness rules our hearts. We don't just need a slight adjustment, we need a complete renovation. Before Christ we were completely lost with no chance of finding life.

*"The heart is deceitful above all things, and desperately sick."
(Jeremiah 17:9)*

As we already saw, even our attempts at goodness fall flat on their face. "We have all become like one who is unclean, and all our righteous deeds are like a polluted garment" (Isaiah 64:6). The law of God written on our hearts bears witness to the standard that we continually break. This is why we are called not only dead in our sin but "by nature children of wrath" (Eph 2:1-3).

Our minds were blinded to spiritual truth. We could not understand or accept spiritual things of God (2 Cor 2:14). We were living in spiritual darkness, sunk to the bottom of the sea with no hope of seeing the light of day.

This is why God's grace is such a big deal. It is while we were still in this sinful state that Jesus died for us! He entered our darkness as the light of the world. He found us on the ocean floor with no hope of floating and raised us to the surface. What was seemingly discarded and laid to waste He renovates and makes new.

Our salvation is completely a work of God's mercy and grace. God initiates this saving work in our lives. Think of a person walking in total darkness, convinced they see clearly but heading toward danger, then someone turns on the light. Similarly, we were blinded by the god of this world but now we see (2 Cor 4:4). We were dead and He has made us alive. We were lost and now we are found. We were hopelessly depraved and now we have been raised.

What should our response to this be? Certainly not pride. It means our salvation is not of ourselves, we have no ground for boasting. It means that Jesus gets all the glory for saving us, that without Him we would be completely lost. It is He who raised the ship.

*For by grace you have been saved through faith.
And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God,
not a result of works, so that no one may boast.
(Ephesians 2:8-9)*

THE VISUAL GOSPEL

Definition

Depravity refers to the deep corruption of human nature due to sin, resulting in our inability to please God, understand spiritual truth rightly, or come to Him apart from His grace.

Reflection Questions

God's Word speaks of unbelievers being "blinded" to spiritual truth (2 Corinthians 4:4). Think back on this experience before you met Jesus. What was it like to be unable to see the things of God clearly?

Read Romans 6:4-5. What was the state of our lives before Jesus? How does our story mirror the resurrection of Jesus?

Gospel Response

Next time you see a cemetery, reflect on all the people who have been laid to rest there. Spiritually, this is who we were before Jesus raises us to new life. Give thanks that though once you were dead, now you are alive!

Prayer

Father of Lights,

Thank you for finding me on the ocean floor. I praise you for shining light into the darkness of my life. Help me to remember that my salvation and new life are completely a work of your Spirit who brought me to life in the midst of my sin. May I walk today in this newness of life, may I walk as a child of the light.

Amen



DAY 7

WRATH

“For the wrath of God is revealed from heaven against all ungodliness and unrighteousness of men...”

Romans 1:18

Greek: οργή (*orge*) — “righteous anger, vengeance, wrath”

Have you ever watched rolling storm clouds draw near on the horizon? When we moved to Ohio from Virginia, we noticed right away that less mountains and hills meant we could see more sky. This has translated to some beautiful sunsets over the years. It also means you can see storms coming! It might not be Kansas, but we get some powerful thunderstorms that roll in like the tide. The power and beauty of a storm will elicit wonder, but the strength and approaching darkness can also arouse fear as can the raging winds and the torrential downpour. The storm clouds of God’s wrath approach us as guilty sinners.

The wrath of God is His holy revulsion against sin and His just judgment against sinners who rebel against His righteous standards. We do not see wrath as a virtue. This is probably because we cannot picture a righteous anger free from an irrational or uncontrolled tantrum. God’s wrath is neither of these things. His wrath is not the result of some divine moodiness. God’s wrath flows

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from His holiness. It is not unjust, unfair, or uncontrolled like our anger often is. The objects of His just wrath are the guilty. God displays His glory through judgment. God hates sin because it is in defiance to His perfect character.

The prophets preached of God's wrath. Nahum warned Nineveh, "the Lord is a jealous and avenging God; the Lord is avenging and wrathful..." (Nahum 1:2). He warns this pagan nation that unless they repent the wrath of God is coming for them.

God cannot for long relent on expressing His just wrath towards sin. Like an impending storm cloud His wrath is being stored up for those who do not repent and receive Christ.

*"You are storing up wrath for yourself on the day of wrath
when God's righteous judgment will be revealed." (Romans 2:5)*

"The wrath of God comes upon the sons of disobedience." (Ephesians 5:6)

God's wrath is coming for sinners. The reality that this truth remains unpopular in the present day says a lot about how much we minimize sin and ignore the holiness and righteousness of God. "God is light, and in him is no darkness at all" (1 John 1:5). God cannot turn a blind eye to sin. If the reality of evil did not arouse God's righteous wrath and zeal, He would not be good at all.

Our hearts bear witness to this too. Our consciences long for justice, for the wicked to be punished. Few things arouse our anger more than seeing the inaction of bystanders when evil is being committed. One cannot be good and at the same time indifferent to evil. Herein lies the problem: we are sinful, wicked and depraved. Every one of us. We all disobey and violate God's character. In so doing we become objects of God's just wrath.

*"Whoever does not obey the Son shall not see life,
but the wrath of God remains on him." (John 3:36)*

His righteous wrath abides on sinners. This is not unjust or unfair—everyone under God's wrath is guilty. Do you sense the storm clouds approaching? This is why the cross matters. "Since, therefore, we have now been justified by his blood, much more shall we be saved by him from the wrath of God" (Romans 5:9). As the modern hymn "In Christ Alone" beautifully says, "Till on that cross as Jesus died, the wrath of God was satisfied..." The gospel means that when we trust in Christ, we are delivered from the wrath to come. We need not fear the impending storm.

Definition

The wrath of God is His holy revulsion against sin and His just judgment against sinners who rebel against His righteous standards.

Reflection Questions

Why do many doubt a God who has wrath for sin? Why is a loving and forgiving God easier for many people to accept than a God who cannot tolerate the presence of sin?

Read John 2:13-17. How does Jesus' response to the desecration of the temple, a holy place of worship, help us see and understand in a concrete way God's wrath toward sin?

Gospel Response

Gaze up at the sky today and when you see a cloud reflect on the storm of God's wrath that was approaching you before Christ. Give thanks that Jesus satisfied the wrath of God for sinners who receive Him.

Prayer

Father God,

Thank you for sending your Son, Jesus, to satisfy your wrath for my sin. Help me to see you as holy and glorious and to understand the depths of my sin and its offense against you. Give me boldness to encourage those who are far from you to flee from the wrath to come and run to you for deliverance.

Amen



DAY 8

JUDGMENT

“And just as it is appointed for man to die once, and after that comes judgment.”

Hebrews 9:27

Greek: κρίσις (*krisis*) – “a separating, trial, selection, or judgment”

Have you ever stood before a judge in a court room as a defendant? Imagine a charge has been set before you, and you know you are guilty. The evidence against you is overwhelming. There is only one verdict: “guilty.” All you feel is hopelessness and despair.

Apart from Christ we are all under judgment. God’s sovereign judgment is His holy and just verdict over the lives of all people, measuring every thought, word, and deed against His perfect standard and assigning eternal consequences accordingly. Who can stand before the righteous Judge of the universe? We all stand guilty before the judgment bench.

“God’s righteous judgment will be revealed. He will render to each one according to his works” (Romans 2:5-6)

It is not just our deeds that will be judged. “Every careless word” we speak and even the “thoughts and intents of the heart” will be laid bare (Matt 12:36; Hebrews 4:12). God is omniscient; He knows all and sees all. Who can stand

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before this comprehensive judgment of the all-seeing Judge?

No one.

Not one.

We like to think of Jesus as all love. We prefer a kind and merciful King, and He certainly is, but we are quick to forget that He is also the holy and supreme Judge of the world with all authority (Matthew 28:18). Of the almost fifty times the word “judgment” is used within the New Testament, Jesus speaks the word 60% of the time. Jesus, the Lamb of God will return as the Lion of Judah, the conquering King and Judge.

“And he has given him authority to execute judgment, because he is the Son of Man. Do not marvel at this, for an hour is coming when all who are in the tombs will hear his voice and come out, those who have done good to the resurrection of life, and those who have done evil to the resurrection of judgment.” (John 5:27-29)

To believe that judgment is not a reality for those who do not know Christ is an insult to the cross. Why did Jesus die at all if there was not a real, and impending judgment for sinners? This coming judgment will lay low all who seek to stand in and of their own righteousness. The jury is out, the verdict is clear and unanimous. You are guilty. This is bad news. The reality is, “we will all stand before the judgment seat of God” (Romans 14:10). Paul continues,

*“For it is written, as I live, says the Lord, every knee shall bow to me, and every tongue shall confess to God. So then each of us will give an account of himself to God.”
(Romans 14:11-12)*

What hope do we have? What kind of good news is this? How then can we ever stand? Are we all doomed?

We cannot stand in and of ourselves, but only if we are dressed in His righteousness alone. Judgment will rain down on us unless Jesus’ blood covers us. Jesus took the judgment we deserved on the cross. He is the Rock in which we can safely dwell on the day of judgment.

*While I draw this fleeting breath,
when mine eyes shall close in death,
when I soar to worlds unknown,
see thee on thy judgment throne,
Rock of Ages, cleft for me,
let me hide myself in thee.*

“Rock of Ages” —Augustus Toplady,

Definition

Judgment is God fairly judging every person's life and giving what is due according to His holy and righteous standard. For those apart from Jesus the verdict is always guilty, resulting in eternal punishment.

Reflection Questions

What comes to your mind when you think of the coming judgment? How does this make you feel?

Read Hebrews 4:12-16. Contrast the reality of being exposed as guilty before God's perfect judgment with the truth that we can have confidence to approach God's throne of grace through Jesus, our perfect High Priest?

Gospel Response

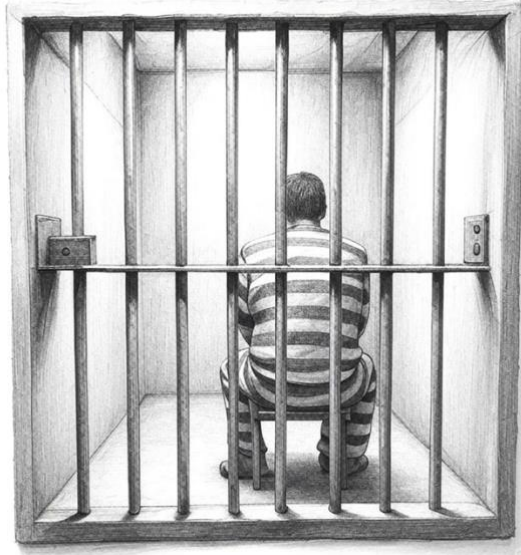
Next time you sit in a chair, reflect on Christ sitting in the judge's seat. Remember that in spite of His perfect knowledge of all of your sin, the case has been dismissed because His blood has cleansed us and the penalty has been paid.

Prayer

Father God,

Thank you that I no longer need to fear the coming judgment. I thank you that I have an Advocate, Jesus Christ the Righteous. Thank you for forgiving me for my sin and trespasses because of Jesus. Help me to live for you and stand in the righteousness of Christ.

Amen



DAY 9

CONDEMNATION

“Whoever believes in him is not condemned, but whoever does not believe is condemned already, because he has not believed in the name of the only Son of God.”

John 3:18

Greek: *κατάκριμα (katakrima)* – “a guilty sentence, verdict, condemnation”

The gavel falls. “Guilty.” The sentence follows: “Life in prison.” You are condemned. No appeals. No second chances. No opportunity for clemency. It is finished. You are done. You are condemned. The jail cell door slams shut.

When the judgment of God falls upon a guilty sinner the verdict is damnation. Condemnation awaits those who are apart from Christ. Only believing in the Son of God, in Jesus, can spare us from this condemnation.

There are many words that describe this condemnation in the New Testament. Death. Hell. Separation. Fire. Perish. All of these are the result of God’s righteous decree of guilt upon sinners. This is what all of us deserve,

“For the wages of sin is death” (Romans 6:23)

This condemnation began in the garden of Eden. After Adam and Eve sinned, God drove them out of the garden (Genesis 3:22-24). Forced

separation. Sin separates us from God.

The sin of Adam and its condemnation have been passed on to all of us.

“The judgment following one trespass brought condemnation, but the free gift following many trespasses brought justification.” (Romans 5:16)

Apart from Christ this condemnation awaits us. It is for us to simply respond in faith to the Lord Jesus Christ. “Whoever believes and is baptized will be saved, but whoever does not believe will be condemned” (Mark 16:16). To not believe, though, is to be “condemned already” (John 3:18).

Condemnation declares that we are not righteous. It is the legal decree of our unrighteousness. In a few days we will look at “justification,” the legal decree through Christ of righteousness; condemnation is the inverse. As J.I. Packer writes, “condemnation is the judicial counterpart to justification: the one pronounces guilt, the other righteousness.”

Condemnation is an unpopular subject in contemporary culture, even in the church. But Jesus had a lot to say about it. He even spoke more about hell than heaven! If the condemnation of God were not such a big deal, then why did Jesus have to walk the road of suffering to the point of death on the cross for us? Salvation does not make sense apart from the reality of condemnation. Condemnation is what we are *saved from*.

Salvation from condemnation is beautifully displayed in an account in John 8 where men throw a woman caught in adultery to the feet of Jesus. The Scribes and Pharisees share that the law of Moses commanded stoning for this sin. Then, seeking to trap Jesus ask, “So, what do you say?”

Jesus ignores their question and begins writing on the ground. He responded, “let him who is without sin among you be the first to throw a stone at her.” Whatever he wrote caused the men to leave one by one. Jesus then asks the woman,

“Woman, where are they? Has no one condemned you?” She said, “No one, Lord.” And Jesus said, “Neither do I condemn you; go, and from now on sin no more.” (John 8:11)

This must be one of the most powerful statements in the Bible. Only Jesus has the power to remove our condemnation, and it is only through His blood. This is why Paul wrote, “There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus” (Romans 8:1). We are the adulterer, the stones should have flown, but Jesus says, to those who trust in Him, “I condemn you no more.”

Definition

Condemnation is God's judicial verdict of guilt for sinners, resulting in the sentence of judgment and eternal separation from God. It is the opposite of justification.

Reflection Questions

When was a time where you were found guilty or shown to be at fault? How did it feel?

Read Romans 8:1. How does this truth that there is no condemnation for the believer change how you relate to God?

Gospel Response

When you close a door today, remember that apart from Christ the jail cell door was slammed shut. There was a closed door of separation between you and God forever. Rejoice that the door has been opened, the jail sentence has already been served by Jesus on your behalf.

Prayer

Father God,

*Thank you for freeing me from the condemnation I deserved, for becoming forsaken on the cross so that I could be set free. Help me to walk in freedom not in condemnation. Silence the voice of the "accuser of the brethren" in my life. Though I was unrighteous, guilty, and condemned you have called me righteous. You have set me free. Thank you, my Savior!
Amen*

PART III
CHRIST'S WORK
What Jesus did to save us from our sin.



DAY 10

INCARNATION

“And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth.”

John 1:14

Greek: σὰρξ (*sarx*) - “flesh, body, living creature”

Incarnation: From Latin *incarnat* meaning “made flesh.”

Growing up I remember a huge anticipation for Christmas. This season was a time of gift giving, family, singing carols, and remembering Jesus, the baby in the manger. In fact, as a child my parents would not let us open any gifts until we first read the Christmas story together. My parents wanted us to remember that the most important Christmas gift was Jesus. The gospel begins in the manger.

God the Son became fully human. His divine nature united with human flesh in the greatest miracle in human history. God became man. Jesus is Immanuel, “God with us.”

Have you ever pondered the miracle of the **incarnation**? The beautiful reality that God entered our broken existence as a man should astonish us! The

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gospel starts here, with a baby. Jesus had to become man in order to be the perfect substitute for us.

“He had to be made like his brothers in every respect... to make propitiation for the sins of the people.” (Hebrews 2:17)

The eternal Son of God took on a human nature without ceasing to be God, becoming one person with two natures—divine and human—forever. One hundred percent God and one hundred percent man. The perfect mediator. The perfect substitute. The only one who could satisfy the wrath of God toward sin.

We celebrate every Christmas, and rightly so, for this is the beginning of the gospel of redemption. The moment God became flesh. Heaven has come to earth, the kingdom of God breaking through into a fallen world. The Son of God humbles Himself by putting on human flesh.

“Have this mind among yourselves, which is yours in Christ Jesus, who, though he was in the form of God, did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped, but emptied himself, by taking the form of a servant, being born in the likeness of men. And being found in human form, he humbled himself by becoming obedient to the point of death, even death on a cross.” (Philippians 2:5-8)

In a miraculous union of two natures, Jesus never ceases to be God: “For in him the whole fullness of deity dwells bodily” (Colossians 2:9). The whole fullness of deity, all of it, in the second Adam. “He is the image of the invisible God” (Colossians 1:15). “He is the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature, and he upholds the universe by the word of his power” (Hebrews 1:3). Without confusion, change, division, or separation, Christ is fully God (true deity) and fully man (true humanity).

The One who spoke the universe into being and who upholds the universe by the word of His power now stands before us in the flesh. The Word became flesh. In so doing, he becomes the perfect High Priest, a Mediator of the New Covenant. A friend.

“There is one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus.” (1 Timothy 2:5)

Theologian Michael Horton states, “the incarnation is the event and process in which the eternal Son of God took to Himself a true and full human nature for the sake of our salvation.” The incarnation is all about the gospel. The manger means God has drawn near to you to “seek and to save that which was lost” (Luke 19:10). He made the first move. A ray of light shone in the darkness of this world one night in Bethlehem. The light of the world comes as a baby in a manger.

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“And she gave birth to her firstborn son and wrapped him in swaddling cloths and laid him in a manger, because there was no place for them in the inn.” (Luke 2:7)

Definition

The incarnation is the act of the second person of the Trinity, the eternal Son of God, assuming a full and true human nature, becoming fully God and fully man in one person, Jesus Christ, to accomplish the work of redemption.

Reflection Questions

What is your favorite thing about Christmas?

How does the gospel start in the manger? Read Matthew 1:21. How was Jesus’ purpose made clear even before His birth?

Gospel Response

When you see a small child or an infant today give thanks that Jesus came into the world, that He put on human flesh, to become our perfect mediator and savior.

Prayer

Father God,

Thank you for coming into this world to save us. Thank you for humbling yourself to the point where you put on human flesh for a sinner such as me. Thank you for how Jesus demonstrates your love and desire to have a relationship with me, to be Immanuel, “God with me.” Help me to walk in an awareness of your nearness today.

Amen



DAY 11

GOSPEL

“And the angel said to them, ‘Fear not, for behold, I bring you good news of great joy that will be for all the people. For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord.’”

Luke 2:10-11

Greek: ευαγγέλιον (*euangelion*) – “good news”

Can you imagine being one of those shepherds on the night of Jesus’ birth! The angel heralds the gospel of Jesus Christ, the Savior of the world to lowly shepherds in the night watches. What a beautiful picture of the gospel! Kingly news relayed to lowly people. The gospel simply means “good news.” And there is none better than Jesus and it is of first importance.

“Now I would remind you, brothers, of the gospel I preached to you, which you received, in which you stand, and by which you are being saved...For I delivered to you as of first importance” (1 Corinthians 15:1-3)

There is no more important news anyone in the world could ever receive than the good news of Jesus, the gospel of Jesus Christ. It is this gospel alone that can save. The good news of the gospel is that the work of reconciliation

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between us and God has already been accomplished. Like Jesus said on the cross, “it is finished.” (John 19:30)

We have seen the bad news of sin, depravity, judgment and condemnation and these encompass the darkness in which the light of the gospel shines forth. Scripture calls this “the light of the gospel of the glory of Christ” (2 Cor 4:4). The gospel is Jesus, the light of the world, who shined in the midst of the darkness of sin and the fall (John 1:5).

Paul lays out the beauty of this gospel and its power in 2 Timothy 1:8-10:

“Share in suffering for the gospel by the power of God, who saved us and called us to a holy calling, not because of our works but because of his own purpose and grace, which he gave us in Christ Jesus before the ages began, and which now has been manifested through the appearing of our Savior Christ Jesus, who abolished death and brought life and immortality to light through the gospel, (2 Timothy 1:8-10)”

This same message of hope is why Jesus came proclaiming the gospel of God: “The time is fulfilled, the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe the gospel” (Mark 1:14-15). The gospel is the good news that Jesus saves those who trust in Him. To put it in a way that is easy to remember, the gospel is simply that through Jesus **God Offers Sinful People Eternal Life**. As the first angelic evangelists proclaimed, “for unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord” (Luke 2:11). That is good news!

This gospel is tied to historic events: the incarnation, crucifixion, resurrection, and ascension, which are not merely spiritual truths but historical realities. Our salvation was accomplished on a real hill called Golgotha (John 19:17), and by a real man, Jesus Christ. It is the gospel that the Apostles continually preached, the message that we should all faithfully share, and the only message that can save.

“For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes.” (Romans 1:16)”

“Go into all the world and proclaim the gospel to the whole creation. Whoever believes and is baptized will be saved, but whoever does not believe will be condemned. (Mark 16:15-16)”

So, follower of Jesus, herald the good news. Shout it from the town square! Light shines in the darkness. Life is offered to the spiritually dead. Hope has a name, and His name is Jesus.

Definition

The gospel is the good news of what God has done in Jesus Christ to save sinners through His life, death, resurrection, and exaltation, calling all people to repent and believe for forgiveness of sins and eternal life.

Reflection Questions

What is the best news you have ever received?

How does understanding the gospel as good news bring light into the darkness of your life? Who can you share the good news of Jesus with today?

Gospel Response

When you see the “news” today whether on a screen, on social media, or in a newspaper, remember the best news that humanity ever received, the good news of Jesus.

Prayer

Good God Above,

Thank you for the good news of Jesus. Thank you that where sin abounded in my life and in the world, grace abounded all the more through your Son, Jesus Christ. Help me to boldly proclaim this good news in my life. Help me to not be ashamed of the gospel and remember that it is the power of God for salvation. Thank you for saving me through Jesus.

Amen



DAY 12

SALVATION

“For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes...”

Romans 1:16

Greek: σωτηρία (sōtēria) – “salvation, deliverance, preservation, safety”

Imagine floating in dark stormy waters miles from land. Your ship has sunk, drowning seems to be your inevitable fate. Then, over the crest of a wave, a light and rescue boat appear. Picture the feeling of being pulled out of the water and having your feet placed on the ship’s deck. Sweet salvation! You are saved. You are safe.

This kind of salvation is at the heart of the gospel; the Christian is saved from perishing.

“For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him should not perish but have eternal life. For God did not send his Son into the world to condemn the world, but in order that the world might be saved through him.

(John 3:16-17)

Have you been saved? This question was more common years ago but

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remains a very Biblical and appropriate question. The reality is that every person is either saved or living in the peril of destruction. Jesus came as a Savior to deliver us from our sin!

*“You shall call His name Jesus, for He will save His people from their sins.
(Matthew 1:21)*

*“For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord.”
(Luke 2:11)*

This Jesus is the source of our salvation and there is no other. Over 20 times in the New Testament Jesus is called our Savior. He is the only rescue boat that is coming! Appropriately enough, even the name Jesus (Or in Hebrew *Yeshua*) means “Yahweh (the LORD) saves” or “Yahweh is salvation.” Jesus’ name is literally our salvation. It is only through the name of Christ that anyone can be saved. For “there is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved” (Acts 4:12). This is the only way to receive eternal life and be saved from eternal death.

“This is good, and it is pleasing in the sight of God our Savior, who desires all people to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth. For there is one God, and there is one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus” (1 Timothy 2:3-5)

To be saved one must come to a knowledge of the Savior and receive His salvation by faith (Eph. 2:8-9; 1 Pet. 1:9). Only faith can save as a result of God’s mercy and grace (Titus 3:5). This is the good news, that we can be saved at all! It is the essence of the gospel which “is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes” (Rom. 1:16).

It is as simple as calling upon the name of the Lord. As it says in Paul’s epistle to the Romans,

“If you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved...For ‘everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved.’” (Romans 10:9, 13)

Have you been saved? Have you trusted in Christ’s work on the cross for your salvation? Have you received the Savior by faith? We were all lost at sea, but then the boat appeared and saved us from sinking into eternal darkness forever.

Definition

Salvation is the gracious and sovereign act of God in which He rescues sinners from sin and judgment through faith in Jesus Christ, restores them to fellowship with Himself, and grants them eternal life by the power of His Spirit.

Reflection Questions

What were you “drowning” in before you met Jesus? What are some of the things you were saved from?

Read Psalm 18:1-19. In what ways does your experience of salvation mirror David’s?

Gospel Response

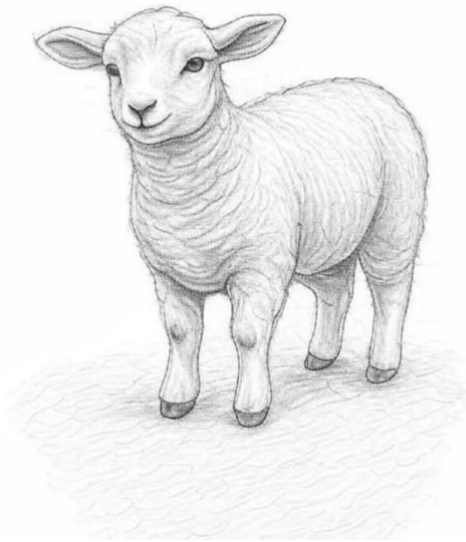
Go to a body of water today, and if you can see a boat even better! Remember your condition before you were saved, being lost at sea. Give thanks for your salvation as you gaze out at the water.

Prayer

My Savior,

Thank you for saving me. I was lost and you found me. I was drowning in my sin and you pulled me out. You are my Savior and I am trusting in you alone for salvation. I praise you and you alone. May I tell the story of you saving me today, boldly proclaiming the gospel of salvation to all who will listen.

Amen



DAY 13

ATONEMENT

“He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree, that we might die to sin and live to righteousness. By his wounds you have been healed.”

1 Peter 2:24

Hebrew: כָּפַר (kāpār) – “to cover, purge, make an atonement”

Atonement: Early 16th century English (denoting unity or reconciliation, especially between God and man from “at-one-ment”)

Jesus took our place. He is our substitutionary atonement. Our sin deserves God’s righteous wrath. The wages of our sin is death (Romans 6:23) and He took this punishment on His shoulders reconciling us to the Father. He took our place. His blood covers our sin and unites us to Christ.

The atonement encompasses everything Christ accomplished to deal with our sin. He is our substitution, cleansing, forgiveness, redemption, propitiation, and reconciliation. He was the sacrificial lamb led to the slaughter for us.

In the Old Testament the Day of Atonement involved both the sacrifice for sin and the removal of sin (symbolized by the scapegoat). Every year the High Priest would sprinkle the blood of a sacrificed bull on the ark of the covenant as a ceremonial purification for Israel to sustain their covenant relationship with God (Leviticus 16).

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In this Old Covenant we learn that “without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness of sins” (Hebrews 9:22). Sin must be covered by blood. These Old Testament sacrifices were pictures of heavenly realities that would ultimately be fulfilled in Jesus who was the better sacrifice, the permanent atonement.

*“We have been sanctified through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for all.”
(Hebrews 10:10)*

The atonement is the work of Christ in His life and especially in His death whereby he bore the penalty for sin, satisfied divine justice, appeased God’s wrath, and reconciled sinners to God. This was accomplished through His substitutionary sacrifice. He took our place. He was the “Lamb of God who takes away the sin of the world” (John 1:29).

“He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree, that we might die to sin and live to righteousness. By his wounds you have been healed.” (1 Peter 2:24)

Christ bore the penalty we deserved. He served the death penalty in our place to wash away our sins. This work of reconciliation is memorialized in the Lord’s supper, where we remember Jesus’ blood by partaking of the cup, “this is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many for the forgiveness of sins” (Matthew 26:28). His blood poured out was our covering, the atonement for all of our sin.

*“How much more will the blood of Christ, who through the eternal Spirit offered himself without blemish to God, purify our conscience from dead works to serve the living God.”
(Hebrews 9:13-14)*

Only Jesus’ blood, shed in our place, can result in our forgiveness. God, in His mercy and grace, sent His Son to take our place. The Lamb that was slain made atonement forever.

“When iniquities prevail against me, you atone for our transgressions.” (Psalm 65:3)

“For the life of the flesh is in the blood, and I have given it for you on the altar to make atonement for your souls, for it is the blood that makes atonement...” (Leviticus 17:11)

Jesus’ blood decidedly atoned for our sin. When we believe in Him, it forever washes our sin away.

*What can wash away my sin?
Nothing but the blood of Jesus.
What can make me whole again?*

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Nothing but the blood of Jesus.

*Nothing can for sin atone:
nothing but the blood of Jesus.
Naught of good that I have done:
nothing but the blood of Jesus.*

*O precious is the flow
that makes me white as snow;
no other fount I know;
nothing but the blood of Jesus.*

“Nothing But the Blood of Jesus”
—Robert Lowry

Definition

Atonement is the once-for-all work of Christ in His life and sacrificial death in which He, as our substitute, bore the penalty of sin, satisfied God’s wrath, fulfilled the demands of divine justice, and reconciled sinners to God securing redemption for all who believe.

Reflection Questions

Have you ever covered up a mistake or something wrong that you did? Did anyone ever find out?

How does Isaiah 1:18 help us understand the extent of the atonement in our lives?

Gospel Response

Grab a pencil, and an eraser. Lightly write some sins that come to your mind in your life or past in the space below with the pencil. Now erase them completely reflecting on the power of the atonement of Christ, the Lamb of God, who’s blood covers and cleanses you from all your sin.

Prayer

Just and Righteous God,

Thank you for offering the sacrifice of your Son in my place. Thank you that his blood is enough to cover all my sins; that though my sins were as scarlet you have washed them white as snow (Isaiah 1:18). Thank you for atoning for my sin.

Amen



DAY 14

PROPTIATION

“He is the propitiation for our sins, and not for ours only but also for the sins of the whole world.”

1 John 2:2

Greek: ἱλασμός (*hilasmos*) – “propitiation, an appeasing”

An average lightning strike generates over a billion watts of power and can reach 50,000 degrees Fahrenheit in temperature. That is five times the temperature of the sun! Obviously, if it were to strike a building it could do a lot of damage!

This is the reason many tall buildings have lightning rods. The Empire State Building in New York City can be struck 100 times in a single year! The purpose of a lightning rod is to carry all of that electrical current to the ground. It attracts and transfers the strike to keep it from harming a structure.

Jesus, hanging on the cross, absorbed all the destructive power of God the Father’s wrath on our behalf. We were the building that should have been struck, and destroyed, but Jesus rose to a prominent place over us and took the lightning for us. His sacrifice satisfies God’s wrath. Christ shields us from God’s righteous judgment.

Propitiation is the act by which God’s righteous wrath against sin is satisfied through the substitutionary death of Christ, making God favorable toward sinners. His wrath is no longer upon those who have received Jesus by faith.

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“for all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus, whom God put forward as a propitiation by his blood, to be received by faith.” (Romans 3:23-25)

Jesus willingly became the lightning rod for us. Unlike a lightning rod, though, Jesus did not just transfer the power to something else, He absorbed it. He satisfied it. Why? Because He loves us.

*“In this is love...that He loved us and sent His Son to be the propitiation for our sins.”
(1 John 4:10)*

God’s love is displayed in this gracious work of giving His only begotten Son to be the propitiation for our sins. He displays His love by *becoming* the propitiation for our sins. This required Him to become like us, to take on the form of man, human flesh and become the perfect substitute.

“Therefore he had to be made like his brothers in every respect, so that he might become a merciful and faithful high priest in the service of God, to make propitiation for the sins of the people.” (Hebrews 2:17; see also Romans 8:3)

Jesus descended to earth as a man to absorb that lightning strike of heaven on your behalf. The next time you hear thunder or see lightning remember the just wrath of God for sinners. The judgment of God that was on you was transferred to the Son. He hung on that cross above you and me as a lightning rod for the wrath of God, that we should gain the righteousness of God in Him.

*And can it be that I should gain
An int'rest in the Savior's blood?
Died He for me, who caused His pain?
For me, who Him to death pursued?
Amazing love! how can it be
That Thou, my God, should die for me?*

“And Can It Be That I Should Gain”
—Charles Wesley

Definition

Propitiation is the act by which God's just wrath against sin is fully satisfied through a sacrificial substitute, Jesus Christ, so that God's favor and forgiveness can be extended to sinners.

Reflection Questions

Was there ever a time where you received a punishment or consequence for something you didn't do? How did that feel?

Read Exodus 34:6-7. How is God described? How does God's mercy and justice find their perfect fulfillment in Jesus' going to the cross to propitiate for our sin?

Gospel Response

Next time you see a storm with lightning and thunder, remember the wrath of God that Jesus absorbed on your behalf. Praise God for the sufficiency of Jesus' work on the cross on your behalf.

Prayer

Heavenly Father,

Thank you for sending your Son as a substitute for me. I deserved that cross. I deserved your wrath. I deserved to be forsaken. Thank you, Jesus, for taking my place. Thank you for dying so that I can live. May I never forget the wondrous cross.

Amen



DAY 15

JUSTIFICATION

*“And are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption
that is in Christ Jesus”
Romans 3:24*

Greek: δικαιώω (*dikaioō*) – “to declare righteous, to justify”

“Not guilty!” The gavel falls. The hammer echoes throughout the court room. The judgment has been pronounced and you are legally declared innocent, free of all charges. You can walk free.

This is the power of justification. The term is forensic, legal. We who are guilty as charged are declared righteous by faith in Christ because of God’s grace alone.

It was an eternal sentence we deserved to pay. We have no hope in ourselves, but for the one who “believes in him who justifies the ungodly, his faith is counted as righteousness” (Romans 4:5). The record of guilt has been wiped away, washed away by the blood of Jesus Christ, for all who trust in Him. How could this be? How could God be “just and the justifier of the one who has faith in Jesus” (Romans 3:26)? Simply put, through the blood shed on the cross of Jesus Christ.

Here on the cross, God’s justice and wrath for sin were satisfied, and the

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righteousness of Christ is offered to sinners. For those who trust in Him, they have this righteousness justly applied to their accounts.

“For our sake he made him to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God.” (2 Corinthians 5:21)

This is the basis of our justification. We are declared righteous because of Christ. His perfection becomes our perfection. His innocence is applied to us. It is nothing we can do. Paul makes it clear, “a person is not justified by works of the law but through faith in Jesus Christ” (Galatians 2:16; see also 3:11). It is only through faith in Christ that we can be declared innocent and have peace with God forever (Romans 5:1; Phil 3:8-9).

Justification is by faith alone and by God’s grace alone through the blood of Christ alone (Romans 5:9). We deserved condemnation because of our sin and the sin of the first Adam, but because of Jesus, the second Adam, we can experience justification: the legal declaration of our innocence before the living God, the Holy Judge of the world (Romans 5:16). What a gift!

Paul continues, “therefore, as one trespass led to condemnation for all men, so one act of righteousness leads to justification and life for all men” (Romans 5:18). Because of justification we are given new life, an eternal life that lasts forever, peace with God everlasting, and reconciliation to our Maker. We are “justified by his grace” so that “we might become heirs according to the hope of eternal life” (Titus 3:7). Justification is permanent. It is sure and the lasting basis of our hope. This is why Paul writes,

“Who shall bring any charge against God’s elect? It is God who justifies. Who is to condemn? Christ Jesus is the one who died—more than that, who was raised—who is at the right hand of God, who indeed is interceding for us.” (Romans 8:33-34)

Jesus, our great high priest, has offered His blood and righteousness as a payment for our justification. We need not fear any judgment or condemnation anymore (Romans 8:1). We have a living hope because we have been declared righteous by God Himself.

*When he shall come with trumpet sound,
O may I then in him be found:
dressed in his righteousness alone,
faultless to stand before the throne.*

“My Hope is Built on Nothing Less”
—Edward Mote

Definition

Justification is the judicial act of God in which he declares sinners righteous in His sight, not on the basis of their works, but solely on the basis of Christ's righteousness imputed to them and received by faith alone.

Reflection Questions

In what ways do we try to justify ourselves before God? Why does this always fail?

Read Romans 8:31-38. How does justification affect our relationship to God?

Gospel Response

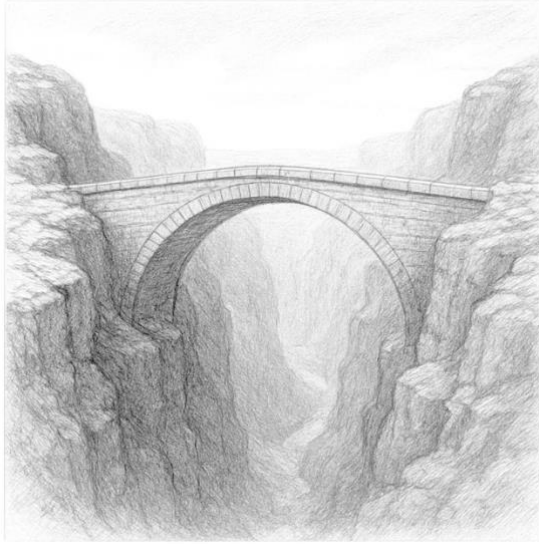
Look for a courthouse or a desk today. When you see it, reflect on the legal decree of "not guilty" being made on your behalf because of Jesus. Give thanks that because of justification you can stand righteous before God.

Prayer

Righteous God,

Thank you for justifying me through Jesus. Thank you that I no longer need to fear condemnation. Help me to daily walk in the confidence that nothing can separate me from the love of Christ. May the reality of my justification silence the accusations of the enemy.

Amen



DAY 16

MEDIATION

“For there is one God, and there is one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus, who gave himself as a ransom for all...”
1 Timothy 2:5-6

Greek: μεσίτης (*mesitēs*) — “one who stands between, a go-between, a reconciler, intercessor, or mediator.”

On November 11, 2025, the Hongqi Bridge in China’s Sichuan province suffered a dramatic partial collapse when a massive landslide tore through its western approach. Spanning a 564-foot-deep ravine, the 2,487-foot-long structure was a critical engineering feat designed to link the inland heartland with the Tibetan Plateau. Suddenly a massive shortcut was lost, the bridge that conveniently linked two regions was now impassable. Though much of the bridge still stood, the portion that collapsed made it useless. It no longer mediated between the two areas.

Jesus Christ bridged the greatest gap in history. That first Christmas, the angel’s announcement spoke truth,

“Glory to God in the highest, and on earth peace among those with whom he is pleased!” (Luke 2:14)

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The angels knew the significance of this unremarkable birth. They knew that this baby brought peace. This baby was the key to creating a bridge between heaven and earth. The Mediator had been born.

In biblical theology, mediation presupposes alienation. Because sin has separated humanity from a holy God, a mediator is required.

“And you, who once were alienated and hostile in mind, doing evil deeds, he has now reconciled in his body of flesh by his death, in order to present you holy and blameless and above reproach before him” (Col. 1:21-22)

Notice how He undoes alienation “in his body of flesh.” Mediation requires a firm connection to both sides. A mediator must truly represent both parties. Jesus alone meets these qualifications by being fully God and fully man. He became the second Adam who could bridge the gap between heaven and earth. The author of Hebrews saw the ministry of Jesus as Mediator as central to His work.

“But as it is, Christ has obtained a ministry that is as much more excellent than the old as the covenant he mediates is better, since it is enacted on better promises.” (Hebrews 8:6)

“Therefore he is the mediator of a new covenant, so that those who are called may receive the promised eternal inheritance, since a death has occurred that redeems them from the transgressions committed under the first covenant.” (Hebrews 9:15; see also 12:24)

Jesus mediates through covenant, a binding agreement between two parties (We will discuss this word at length in a few days). His blood becomes the currency through which the covenant is secured. He stands between God and man, uniting the two through His blood. Poetically, Christ hangs there on the cross, arms stretched wide, shedding his blood to bridge the gap between our sin and God’s holiness. In His perfection and humanity, He perfectly mediates the new covenant.

His mediating work continues today. Jesus, after being raised from the dead, ascended to the right hand of God the Father and He lives to make intercession for those who are His.

“Consequently, he is able to save to the uttermost those who draw near to God through him, since he always lives to make intercession for them.” (Hebrews 7:25)

“Who is to condemn? Christ Jesus is the one who died—more than that, who was raised—who is at the right hand of God, who indeed is interceding for us.” (Romans 8:34)

Jesus connects us to God. He bridges the gap our sin created. Even now, when we fall short, His blood speaks a better word. Our fellowship with God

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can be continually restored through our great Mediator. The gospel is the good news of a bridge that has been built between God and man; a bridge anyone can cross, if they come through Christ by faith (John 14:6).

Definition

Mediation is the work of Jesus Christ, the God-man, by which He stands between God and sinful humanity as the only representative who reconciles the two by His atoning death and ongoing intercession as our Great High Priest.

Reflection Questions

Can you think of a time you were in the role of mediator in your family, with friends, or in a work setting? How did you seek to represent both sides?

What is the significance of Jesus becoming a man, taking on human flesh, in his work of mediation?

Gospel Response

If you see a bridge today, consider the work of Christ on the cross that bridged the gap between us, undeserving sinners, and a holy God. Approach God's throne of grace in prayer confidently, knowing that Jesus is the perfect Mediator.

Prayer

Holy God,

I am unworthy to approach you in and of myself. Thank you for sending your one and only Son, Jesus, to make a way back to you. Thank you, Jesus, for dying on the cross for me so that I can have full communion with God. Thank you for bridging the gap, for mediating a new and better covenant with your blood.

Amen



DAY 17

REDEMPTION

*“In him we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of our trespasses,
according to the riches of his grace”
Ephesians 1:7*

Greek: ἀπολυτρωσις (*apolutrōsis*) – “redemption, deliverance, liberation, a releasing effected by payment of ransom”

Tragedy struck. Ruth, a Moabite woman, lost her Jewish husband, her means of provision, *and* her father-in-law in quick succession! She now finds herself vulnerable and poor. She demonstrates faithfulness to Naomi, her mother-in-law, and returns with her to Israel where she lives in poverty, gleaning from the crops, trying to survive by picking up what the harvesters leave behind.

It is in this place that God sends a redeemer. A distant relative, Boaz, sees her and then agrees to redeem her and her husband’s inheritance. He pays the price and does not just provide for her, he marries her!

This Old Testament foreshadowing beautifully illustrates what our Redeemer does for us. He finds us in our spiritual poverty, indebted to our sin, then takes us out of this place of need and bondage to the enemy by paying the price of His blood to free us and give us hope. What a cost!

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*“In him we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of our trespasses,
according to the riches of his grace.” (Ephesians 1:7)*

Did you notice how Jesus redeems us? The currency He pays is His blood. The atonement, the blood of the lamb, serves as the payment for our freedom. The blood of Christ is the purchase price. His payment was costly to Him but is offered to us as a free gift.

“For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus, whom God put forward as a propitiation by his blood, to be received by faith.” (Romans 3:23-25)

This is what Paul says in 1 Corinthians 6, we were “bought with a price”! We were purchased at the price of Jesus’ blood. The Apostle Peter explains that we “were ransomed from the futile ways...not with perishable things such as silver or gold, but with the precious blood of Christ, like that of a lamb without blemish or spot” (1 Peter 1:18-19, See also Hebrews 9:12).

This is why Jesus came! “Even as the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many.” (Matthew 20:28; See also Mark 10:45) Jesus “gave himself for us to redeem us from all lawlessness and to purify for himself a people for his own possession who are zealous for good works” (Titus 2:14). What a comfort to know that Jesus came to redeem us. That through this act of kindness He transferred our address:

“He has delivered us from the domain of darkness and transferred us to the kingdom of his beloved Son, in whom we have redemption, the forgiveness of sins.” (Colossians 1:13-14)

What should our response be to this redemption? It can only be praise and thanksgiving! We have been purchased and given a new life, and He is worthy of our song (Rev. 5:9).

*“Oh give thanks to the Lord, for he is good,
for his steadfast love endures forever!
Let the redeemed of the Lord say so,
whom he has redeemed from trouble”
(Psalm 107:1-2)*

*Redeemed, how I love to proclaim it!
Redeemed by the blood of the Lamb!
redeemed through His infinite mercy—
His child, and forever, I am.*

*“Redeemed, How I Love to Proclaim It!”
—Fanny Crosby*

Definition

Redemption is God's gracious act of purchasing and freeing His people from slavery to sin, death, and judgment through the payment of Christ's blood, securing their release and restoration to Him.

Reflection Questions

What is the greatest debt you ever owed? How would it have felt if someone else came along and paid it completely off?

"Redemption is free, but it is not cheap." Reflect on this truth. What was the cost of our redemption?

Gospel Response

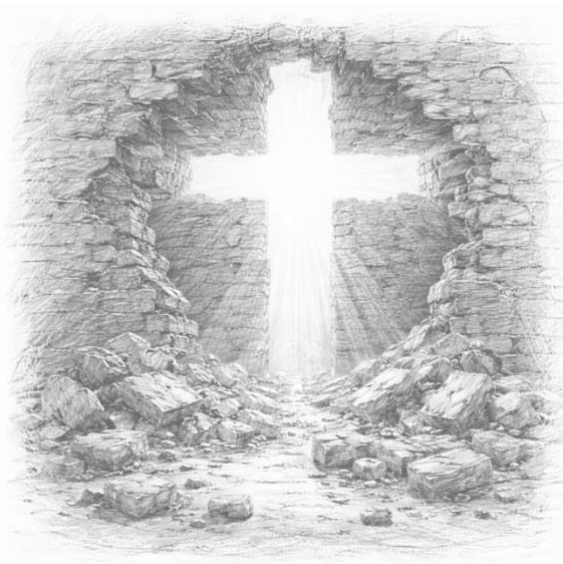
Look for an opportunity to pay for someone's bill or do something that is usually another's responsibility. Do so as anonymously as you can manage. Give thanks that Christ paid the price we owed even when we were dead in our sin.

Prayer

My Redeemer,

Thank you for paying the price that I owed. Thank you for purchasing my life with your blood. Help me to live in constant awareness of your sacrifice for me. May I never become entitled or ungrateful but rather walk in gratitude every day.

Amen



DAY 18

RECONCILIATION

“For in him all the fullness of God was pleased to dwell, and through him to reconcile to himself all things, whether on earth or in heaven, making peace by the blood of his cross.”

Colossians 1:19-20

Greek: καταλλαγή (*katallagē*) – “reconciliation, to change from enmity to friendship”

Greek: ειρήνη (*eirēnē*) – “peace, harmony, wholeness, rest, restoration”

On June 12, 1987, at the Brandenburg Gate, United States president Ronald Reagan delivered a speech remembered for one key phrase, “Mr. Gorbachev, tear down this wall!” Reagan called for Soviet leader Mikhail Gorbachev to open the Berlin Wall, which had encircled West Berlin since 1961. It was over two years before this wall fell and three before the complete reconciliation of East and West Germany took place but this moment is widely remembered as a turning point towards the re-unification of Germany. They were one nation again. The wall had finally fallen.

Over 700 years before Jesus died on the cross, the prophet Isaiah spoke of a suffering servant who was “pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with

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his wounds we are healed” (Isaiah 53:5). Jesus came as the Prince of Peace to reconcile us to God the Father forever (Isaiah 9:6).

Sin had created a wall of division between us and God. But Christ, through His work on the cross, has torn down the dividing wall. He has made a way through. Separation is no more. We have been brought near.

But now in Christ Jesus you who once were far off have been brought near by the blood of Christ. For he himself is our peace, who has made us both one and has broken down in his flesh the dividing wall of hostility... that he might reconcile us both to God in one body through the cross, thereby killing the hostility. (Ephesians 2:13–16)

He has literally “killed the hostility.” If you have ever experienced estrangement or conflict, you know what it is to lack peace. Jesus came to give us peace with God the Father.

“Therefore, since we have been justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ.” (Romans 5:1)

The reconciliation that Christ bought with His blood made enemies friends. Instead of having an enemy on the other side of the wall, the wall is torn down and peace is forever established (Romans 5:10). This is a gift from God. Paul writes, “All this is from God, who through Christ reconciled us to himself” (2 Corinthians 5:18).

Only Jesus could atone for our sin. Only the God-man could mediate this dividing wall. Only Jesus could justify us before the Holy Judge. Only Jesus could rescue us from Heaven’s wrath by taking it upon His shoulders. Only the Son of God could tear down this “wall of hostility.”

“For in him all the fullness of God was pleased to dwell, and through him to reconcile to himself all things, whether on earth or in heaven, making peace by the blood of his cross.” (Colossians 1:19–20)

The sledgehammer that took the wall down was the blood of Jesus Christ. We are no longer estranged. We need not fear. We have been reconciled to God through faith in Jesus. We have peace. He is our peace.

“For he himself is our peace.” (Ephesians 2:14)

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Definition

Reconciliation is God ending the war and separation our sin created by the blood of His Son, Jesus Christ, and granting us lasting peace with Himself.

Reflection Questions

Have you ever been in conflict with someone and then had the conflict peacefully resolve? How did that feel when the tension was removed?

Read Romans 5:10. In what ways were you an enemy of God before Christ? How are we reconciled to God?

Gospel Response

When you see a wall or a fence today remember that Jesus tore down that dividing wall between us and God the Father. Praise Him for reconciling us to our Maker.

Prayer

God of peace,

I praise you for sending your Son to reconcile me to yourself. Thank you for forsaking Jesus so I could be brought near. Thank you for sending the Prince of Peace to fix my relationship with you forever. May I continue to draw near to you every day through Jesus, the Reconciler.

Amen



DAY 19

FORGIVENESS

*"In whom we have redemption, the forgiveness of sins."
Colossians 1:14*

Greek: ἀφεσις (*aphesis*) – “release, pardon, cancellation of debt, forgiveness”

I was 22 years old and about to pop the question to the most amazing woman I had ever met. Sarah, my now wife of 16 years, was brought into my life by the Lord and she was the perfect match. I couldn't wait to spend the rest of my life with her. I had asked her father's permission, I had purchased the ring, and now I was waiting for the right moment. There was one heavy reality that caused a degree of soberness in this proposal: Sarah had a significant amount of school debt. This didn't cause me pause in wanting to marry her, but it certainly added a level of seriousness to the commitment. Her debt would become *our* debt.

Unbeknownst to Sarah, it was the day before my planned proposal, and we were having lunch together. Sarah shared with me how her parents had inherited some money from a relative who had passed away and were choosing to use a portion of it to completely pay off her school debt! What a confirmation! I could have gotten down on one knee right there in the dining room of Chick-fil-A! The debt had been paid. We were released from the weight of that huge financial responsibility. The debt was forgiven forever.

The idea of forgiveness in the Bible relates to the “cancellation of a debt.”

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It is like having a bill burned up or thrown in the shredder. The shedding of Christ's blood is our redemption, and it results in the forgiveness of our debt of sin.

"In him we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of our trespasses, according to the riches of his grace." (Ephesians 1:7)

*"He has delivered us from the domain of darkness and transferred us to the kingdom of his beloved Son, in whom we have redemption, the forgiveness of sins."
(Colossians 1:13–14)*

"For this is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many for the forgiveness of sins." (Matthew 26:28)

The author of Hebrews makes it clear "without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness of sins" (Hebrews 9:22). Jesus' blood purchased our forgiveness. The debt cannot be forgiven without someone paying the price or taking a loss. This is Jesus. He paid the price on our behalf, that our debt might be forgiven.

This is at the heart of the gospel that the early church proclaimed and what we too are called to share.

"Repentance for the forgiveness of sins should be proclaimed in his name to all nations, beginning from Jerusalem" (Luke 24:47, see also Acts 26:18)

*"And Peter said to them, "Repent and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins, and you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit."
(Acts 2:38)*

This is one of the most glorious works of the gospel: having our debt of sin forgiven! People often speak of wanting to be "blessed" and wanting that "blessed life," but the reality is that forgiveness is one of the greatest blessings a sinner can have. The Psalmist writes, and Paul later quotes in Romans,

*"Blessed are those whose lawless deeds are forgiven, and whose sins are covered"
(Psalm 85:2 and Romans 4:7)*

Our debt is owed to God and He alone can forgive sins (Matt 9:6, Mark 2:4-9). The beauty of the gospel is that when we come to the Father through faith in Christ, He forgives, every single time.

"If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness." (1 John 1:9)

Definition

Forgiveness is the gracious act of God by which He fully pardons sinners of their guilt, cancels their debt of sin, and no longer holds their transgressions against them because of Christ's work on the cross.

Reflection Questions

How is God's forgiveness different then how we as fallen humans normally forgive?

Read Psalm 103:12. When God forgives, what is the extent of His forgiveness?

Gospel Response

Next time you make a payment or pay a bill, stop and tell God how grateful you are for His forgiving your debt of sin through the blood of Jesus.

Prayer

Forgiving God,

Thank you for paying my debt. Thank you that I am free from the debt of sin I owed. Help me to walk in the reality of your total forgiveness of my sin through Jesus. Strengthen me to forgive others who sin against me in the same way you have forgiven me (Ephesians 4:32). Thank you for your mercy and grace.

Amen



DAY 20

COVENANT

“Therefore he is the mediator of a new covenant, so that those who are called may receive the promised eternal inheritance, since a death has occurred that redeems them from the transgressions committed under the first covenant.”

Hebrews 9:15

Greek: διαθήκη (*diatheke*) – “covenant, testament, binding agreement”

Have you ever felt like a fish out of water? As a pastor I have had the privilege of officiating almost a dozen weddings. It has been one of the highest privileges of ministry, to be asked to share in this sacred moment between the couple. When I know both the bride and the groom well, which has happened a few times, it is especially sweet. Even in cases like this, when there is a familiarity with the couple, there is a sense of awkwardness being that close to them. As they look into one another’s eyes and share vows, as they exchange their rings with words of commitment, or as they share their first kiss, I can’t help but feel like I am too close to something very private, very personal. I have no part in their words: “til death do us part.”

Marriage is a covenant. It is a sacred promise and a binding agreement. One of the enemy’s greatest attacks on the gospel in modern times is his attack on

marriage, God's designed portrait of the gospel (See Ephesians 5:32). This comes in the form of open marriage where the covenant is not exclusive, no-fault divorce where the marriage is not really binding, and no marriage where permanent commitment is not necessary to live together, sleep together, and have children. These things are the opposite of biblical covenant. Look at Jesus' words in Matthew 19:4-6,

"[Jesus] answered, 'Have you not read that he who created them from the beginning made them male and female, and said, 'Therefore a man shall leave his father and his mother and hold fast to his wife, and the two shall become one flesh'? So they are no longer two but one flesh. What therefore God has joined together, let not man separate.'"

This is covenant language. Marriage is a covenant. A relationship built on promise. Malachi, in speaking of marital unfaithfulness, ties marriage directly to the Biblical word for covenant, "she is your companion and your wife by covenant" (Malachi 2:14). The implication is this: the essence of covenant should be faithfulness. It is a binding agreement.

Covenant is one of the great themes of Scripture. There is covenant imagery all throughout the Old Testament. From Adam to Noah, Abraham to Jacob, and Moses to David. The Old Testament consistently points to a God who relates to mankind through covenant. Almost every time, God's covenants are sealed with a blood sacrifice. Think of the Holy of Holies, the inner most sanctuary of the Hebrew tabernacle and temple. What object is central to this place? The Ark of the Covenant. Annually, the high priest would enter this holiest place on the day of atonement and sprinkle the blood of a goat on the mercy seat, the lid of the Ark, for the sins of the people. God has always established relationship with humanity through covenant.

Then, in the midst of the destruction of the temple and Israel being taken into the Babylonian captivity, two prophets promised a new covenant. Jeremiah and Ezekiel both spoke of a new covenant that would transform the heart.

"Behold, the days are coming, declares the LORD, when I will make a new covenant with the house of Israel and the house of Judah, not like the covenant that I made with their fathers on the day when I took them by the hand to bring them out of the land of Egypt, my covenant that they broke, though I was their husband, declares the LORD. For this is the covenant that I will make with the house of Israel after those days, declares the LORD: I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their hearts. And I will be their God, and they shall be my people...For I will forgive their iniquity, and I will remember their sin no more." (Jeremiah 31:34; See also Ezekiel 36:26-27)

Then Jesus shows up, "the Lamb of God who takes away the sin of the world" (John 1:29). And what does He say on the night before His crucifixion?

"And he took a cup, and when he had given thanks he gave it to them, saying, 'Drink

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of it, all of you, for this is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many for the forgiveness of sins.” (Matthew 26:27-28)

The author of Hebrews spends whole chapters explaining how all the covenants before were but a foreshadowing of this new and greater covenant in Jesus. A divinely established, binding relationship with God that is established through the sacrifice of Jesus on the cross. We learn that Jesus entered a heavenly tabernacle, “by means of his own blood” to offer Himself as a sacrifice for us. “He is the mediator of a new covenant” (See Hebrews 9:11-15). And the proof that this sacrifice was received, and the covenant was forever established, was the temple’s veil, that wall of separation, was torn in two (See Matthew 27:51). We have been reconciled forever to God through Christ *by covenant*.

Every time the church partakes in communion together, they are remembering the covenant that was established through Jesus’ sacrifice. That, because His body was broken and His blood was shed, God will remember our sins no more. “This cup is the new covenant in my blood; do this, whenever you drink it, in remembrance of me” (1 Corinthians 11:25). Covenant means that the blood of Jesus speaks a better word for those who have received Christ by faith. And even death cannot do us part (Romans 8:38-39).

Definition

A covenant is a divinely established, binding relationship in which God commits Himself to His people with promises and often confirms it with signs and blood.

Reflection Questions

How does the unconditional nature of the new covenant, its being based entirely on the blood of Jesus shed for us, free us from guilt, shame, and dread even when we fail?

How do the promises of God in Christ relate to wedding vows? What promises given in the new covenant can you hold tightly to today? (Example: Hebrews 13:5)

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Gospel Response

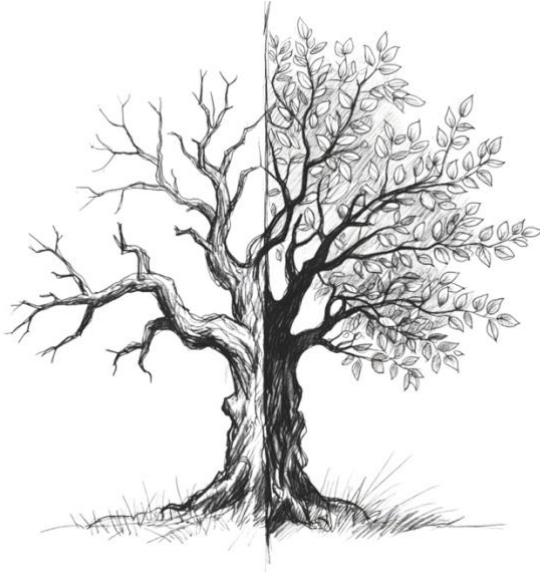
The next time you partake in the Lord's Supper, intentionally reflect on the new covenant. Give thanks for the blood of Christ which has washed away your sin and established your relationship with God forever through covenant.

Prayer

Now may the God of peace who brought again from the dead the Lord Jesus, the great shepherd of the sheep, by the blood of the eternal covenant, equip me with everything good that I may do his will, working in me that which is pleasing in his sight, through Jesus Christ, to whom be glory forever and ever. (Hebrews 13:20-21)

Amen.

PART IV
THE SPIRIT'S ROLE
How the Spirit changes us from the inside out.



DAY 21

REGENERATION

“He saved us, not because of works done by us in righteousness, but according to his own mercy, by the washing of regeneration and renewal of the Holy Spirit.”

Titus 3:5

Greek: παλιγγενεσία (*palingenesia*) – “rebirth, regeneration”

Greek: ζωοποιέω (*zōopoieō*) – “to make alive”

Years ago, there was a beautiful maple tree in our front yard. It had a few dying branches but it remained a nice shade tree. There was a small visible hollow on the tree where one year a small screech owl made that little hole his home! It was a joy watching him sit in the hollow surveying the world below.

One year, seemingly out of nowhere, half the tree fell over barely missing our house! It turns out the whole tree had experienced core rot; outwardly it looked good, but the rot left the inside hollow. It was only a matter of time before the entire tree would be dead and leafless. We too, though physically alive, are inwardly dead. As we have already seen, we were “dead in our trespasses and sin,” but then, “God, being rich in mercy, because of the great love with which he loved us...made us alive together with Christ” (Ephesians 2:4-5; See also Colossians 2:13). We were brought back to life. Born again.

Regenerated.

This work of resurrection brings us from spiritual deadness to spiritual life. The Bible teaches that this regenerative work, this coming to life, is accomplished by the Holy Spirit when we are saved.

"He saved us, not because of works done by us in righteousness, but according to his own mercy, by the washing of regeneration and renewal of the Holy Spirit." (Titus 3:5)

This was a work of God's Spirit according to His will. As James writes, "of his own will he brought us forth by the word of truth, that we should be a kind of firstfruits of his creatures" (James 1:18; See Also Romans 8:11). This resurrection, the new birth, was a promised reality in the new covenant.

*"And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh. And I will put my Spirit within you, and cause you to walk in my statutes and be careful to obey my rules."
(Ezekiel 36:26-27)*

Just as God breathed into Adam the breath of life, in regeneration God breathes into a human soul new spiritual life. The believer has been born again (John 3:5-8). Jesus told Nicodemus in that late night conversation that unless a man be reborn "he cannot enter the kingdom of God" (John 3:5)! To be saved, to receive the gospel, is to be born again. Those who experience this new life will never perish "since [they] have been born again, not of perishable seed but of imperishable, through the living and abiding word of God" (1 Peter 1:23). The Word of God is the seed that brings forth spiritual life (Matthew 13:1-23).

This new life is only possible in Christ. He was the firstborn back from the dead (Colossians 1:18). And just as the Father raised Jesus from the dead, "in Christ shall all be made alive" (1 Corinthians 15:22). Eternal life, the regenerative work of the Holy Spirit is both a present reality and a future promise. It is something the believer has possession of because he is no longer dead, he is alive. We have been made new.

"Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away; behold, the new has come." (2 Corinthians 5:17)

Definition

Regeneration is being born again through the Holy Spirit. It is a supernatural work of God in which a spiritually dead person is made alive.

Reflection Questions

When you came to know Christ what was your experience of coming alive? What changed when you were regenerated?

Read 2 Corinthians 5:17. What old things, those characteristics of the old dead man, do you need to put off? What new things, fruits of the Spirit, do you need to put on?

Gospel Response

Look for a dead or dying tree or plant today. When you find one, remember who you were before you were made alive through the work of the Spirit. Give thanks for the gospel that has given you new life in Christ!

Prayer

Awesome God,

Thank you for sending your Spirit and raising me to new life. Thank you for changing me, for opening my eyes to see Jesus. Thank you for transforming me and giving me a new nature. I thank you that I have been born again!

Amen



DAY 22

SEALING

“In him you also, when you heard the word of truth, the gospel of your salvation, and believed in him, were sealed with the promised Holy Spirit”

Ephesians 1:13

Greek: σφραγίζω (*sphragizō*) — “to seal, mark with ownership”

Have you ever received some proof of ownership? Perhaps a deed or title? This legal document, perhaps to a house or a car or another piece of property, demonstrates a right of possession. Similarly, official documents like a marriage certificate or a diploma demonstrate a legal reality. Many of these documents have an official seal, a formal mark of endorsement, authenticity, and authority. They are traditionally used by governments and officials to validate documents. Historically, it represented the binding, irrevocable nature of a decree. It acts as a signature, a “seal of approval.”

To be a Christian is to be sealed by the Holy Spirit. God gives His Spirit as evidence that we are His. We belong to Him.

“Or do you not know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit within you, whom you have from God? You are not your own, for you were bought with a price. So glorify God

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in your body.” (1 Corinthians 6:19-20)

We are possessed by God. When we are saved, we are indwelt by the Holy Spirit of God as a mark of ownership. We have a new identity and a new nature. We have been born again unto a new life. We have been transformed and brought into the kingdom of our God.

This legal image ensures our permanent membership in the family of God. Paul writes, “you have received the Spirit of adoption as sons, by whom we cry, ‘Abba! Father!’” (Romans 8:15). The Apostle John writes similarly, “see what kind of love the Father has given to us, that we should be called children of God; and so we are” (1 John 3:1). By royal decree, at the point of our salvation, our adoption papers are sealed with the mark of heaven.

This again is completely a work of God that was undeserved. We did not earn our way into His family. We do not deserve to be safe and secure in our hope. But a faithful God gives us this secure and steadfast hope as a promise.

*“And it is God who establishes us with you in Christ, and has anointed us, and who has also put his seal on us and given us his Spirit in our hearts as a guarantee.”
(2 Corinthians 1:21–22)*

You can take that to the bank! The seal of the King of Heaven is secure. The gift and indwelling of God’s Spirit bears witness that we are His. We are no longer dead in our flesh but have been made alive in the Spirit. For those who are in Christ, you “are not in the flesh but in the Spirit, if in fact the Spirit of God dwells in you. Anyone who does not have the Spirit of Christ does not belong to him” (Romans 8:9). The Spirit guarantees we are His forever; “you were sealed for the day of redemption” (Ephesians 4:30).

You are sealed the Spirit of God whom Jesus promised as a gift to all believers. “[The Father] will give you another Helper, to be with you forever, even the Spirit of truth” (John 14:16). When you heard the gospel and believed in Christ as your Lord and Savior this Helper came to dwell in you. You were “sealed with the promised Holy Spirit, who is the guarantee of our inheritance until we acquire possession of it, to the praise of his glory” (Ephesians 1:13–14).

In Christ your ownership has been transferred. Your future is secure. The contract has been signed. You are His. Your fate has been *sealed*.

Definition

Sealing is the divine act by which the Holy Spirit marks believers as God's own possession, guarantees their future inheritance, and secures them for salvation.

Reflection Questions

In what ways does the sealing of the Holy Spirit help us know that we are safe, belonging to God forever?

Read Philippians 1:6. How does the work of the Spirit in sealing and indwelling guarantee this promise?

Gospel Response

Next time you sign your signature on something, remember the signet ring by which you were sealed. Give thanks that God the Father sealed you with His Holy Spirit, claiming you as His forever.

Prayer

Father God,

Thank you for sending your Spirit into my life as a guarantee that I am yours. When the Spirit convicts me of sin, help me to confess it and by the power of the Spirit go and sin no more. I thank you that my being safe in your family does not depend on my performance, but it is safely secured and upheld by the Spirit. I thank you that I am kept and held by you.

Amen



DAY 23

ADOPTION

“In love he predestined us for adoption to himself as sons through Jesus Christ, according to the purpose of his will”
Ephesians 1:4-5

Greek: υιοθεσία (*huiiothesia*) — adoption, adoption of children

I remember the first adoption ceremony I ever attended. A family in our church was adopting a sweet little girl named, Maevah, into their home. It was a surreal moment as the parents, who had been Maevah’s foster parents for quite some time, took legal responsibility for this child. They had been caring for her already, but now there was a permanency to this relationship. She was part of a new family. Her last name had changed. She was adopted. Dozens from our church family attended this legal ceremony in the courtroom that day. When the gavel fell sounds of joy broke through the formal air: cheering, clapping, and happy tears. Maevah now had a home. It mirrored the beautiful truth of our adoption into the family of God when we receive Christ.

“See what kind of love the Father has given to us, that we should be called children of God; and so we are.” (1 John 3:1)

What struck me in that court room was the supreme act of unconditional love, sacrifice, and commitment that was demonstrated by the new parents. They signed on the dotted line. “She is ours.” What a demonstration of love! This is what God does to us when we come to faith in Him. He does not just cleanse us from our sin and apply the righteousness of Christ to us; He adopts us into His family. Far better than just forgiving an offense, we now belong to Him, as His children. John Piper writes, “Adoption is greater than justification because justification is the means and adoption is the end. Justification is like the pardon of a rebel, but adoption is the promotion to sonship.” Here we continue to witness the beautiful blessings of being in Christ. The gospel is the good news that we can be reconciled to God; it is about relationship. We have peace with our heavenly Father forever!

The New Testament holds the status of sonship exclusively for those who are believers. As the Apostle John wrote in his gospel,

“Yet to all who did receive him, to those who believed in his name, he gave the right to become children of God” (John 1:12)

Notice adoption is the result of saving faith. It is only through Jesus that we can be called children of God. Before we were saved we were actually “children of the devil” (John 8:44)! This demonstrates the marvelous work of the Holy Spirit who has led us out of the kingdom of darkness and into the kingdom of light (1 Peter 2:9). Scripture speaks to this new familial identity as being “children of the light” (See John 12:36 Ephesians 5:8-10; 1 Thessalonians 5:5). This new family is set apart unto righteousness and holiness for the glory of God.

Paul speaks to this new reality of adoption for the believer in Romans and Galatians beautifully describing the reality of God now being our “Abba,” or “Daddy,” and our new status as heirs.

“For all who are led by the Spirit of God are sons of God. For you did not receive the spirit of slavery to fall back into fear, but you have received the Spirit of adoption as sons, by whom we cry, ‘Abba! Father!’ The Spirit himself bears witness with our spirit that we are children of God, and if children, then heirs—heirs of God and fellow heirs with Christ, provided we suffer with him in order that we may also be glorified with him.”
(Romans 8:14-17)

“But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law, to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons. And because you are sons, God has sent the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, crying, ‘Abba! Father!’ So you are no longer a slave, but a son, and if a son, then an heir through God.” (Galatians 4:4-7)

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Sons don't earn their status. A child is a child by nature and by the legal decree of adoption. This is the reality. You have a new family. You are dearly loved by your Heavenly Father. You are his child. And an heir! You have an inheritance waiting for you (1 Peter 1:4).

Praise God that He has adopted us into His family,

"According to the purpose of His will, to the praise of His glorious grace, with which He has blessed us in the Beloved" (Ephesians 1:5-6).

Definition

Adoption means God welcomes believers into His family as dear children, giving us full rights and love as heirs in Christ.

Reflection Questions

How does being a child of God increase your sense of belonging?

In what ways should viewing other Christians as part of your eternal family change how you respond to conflict?

When you feel lonely or unwanted, how does the doctrine of adoption tell our hearts a different story?

Gospel Response

When you pray this week make an intentional effort to pray to God as Father, remembering that He has adopted you into His family.

Prayer

Father God,

Thank you for adopting me into your family as Your child. Help me to remember who I am and what I have waiting for me as an heir in your kingdom. Help me to walk as a child of light in this world of darkness. May I see other Christians as my brothers and sisters. Would you increase my love for Your church, the family of God. Thank you for caring for me as a good, good Father.

Amen



DAY 24

RESCUE

“He has rescued us from the domain of darkness and transferred us into the kingdom of the Son He loves.”

Colossians 1:13

Greek: *ῥύομαι* (*rhuomai*) – “to rescue or deliver”

My friend Aaron works for an organization that rescues girls from sex trafficking in Asia. Most of these girls are minors who have been forced into brothels to earn money for their families and employers. They know no other life and struggle to imagine what freedom would look like. Aaron and his team go into dark places to offer freedom to these girls. They give them a place to live, teach them a trade, and offer them hope in Jesus. They seek to deliver them from this life of darkness. Aaron literally frees trapped slaves. He delivers them from a great evil.

Jesus rescues us. He delivers us from the fire. While we were dead in our sin and enslaved to the ruler of the darkness of this world, Jesus came to our rescue. “He has delivered us from the domain of darkness...” (Colossians 1:13). Where salvation is general and broad, deliverance is personal and specific. Jesus was the Deliverer who heard our cry for mercy and came running.

“The Deliverer will come from Zion, he will banish ungodliness from Jacob”
(Romans 11:26; See also Isaiah 59:20-21)

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The very essence of rescue means that we were trapped. We needed someone else to deliver us. We needed an outside force to come to our aid. There was no way out. We were like the children of Israel in Egypt who cried out and God heard. We can relate to the Psalmist who wrote,

*“The cords of death encompassed me; the torrents of destruction assailed me;
the cords of Sheol entangled me; the snares of death confronted me.
In my distress I called upon the Lord; to my God I cried for help.
From his temple he heard my voice, and my cry to him reached his ears...
He sent from on high, he took me; he drew me out of many waters.
He rescued me from my strong enemy” (Psalm 18:4-6, 16-17)*

God promises to rescue His own forever (Psalm 71:1-3). Paul, in the midst of opposition held onto this promise as he served as an ambassador of light in the darkness of this world; “the Lord will rescue me from every evil deed and bring me safely into His heavenly kingdom” (2 Timothy 4:18). God will rescue His children from all darkness and evil. We need not fear for our Deliverer is coming.

This work of rescue for the Christian is done by Christ, the Lamb of God, the Messiah. His work of salvation is a work of deliverance and rescue. He saves us! This rescue mission delivered us from the wrath to come. “You turned to God from idols to serve the living and true God, and to wait for his Son from heaven, whom he raised from the dead, Jesus who delivers us from the wrath to come” (1 Thessalonians 1:9-10). Jesus is the Deliverer that has been promised. He snatched us out of the darkness and from the power of Satan and sin. A similar word, meaning to “pluck” or “snatch out,” is used by Paul in Galatians.

“Grace to you and peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ, who gave himself for our sins to deliver us from the present evil age, according to the will of our God and Father, to whom be the glory forever and ever. Amen.” (Galatians 1:3-4)

We were trapped in a burning building and Jesus, like a faithful fireman, came in and pulled us out. He rescued us, delivering us from the flames. Paul echoes this same idea, foreshadowing the day when we are forever rescued from the presence of sin in Romans 7,

“Who will rescue me from this body of death? Thanks be to God through Jesus Christ our Lord!” (Romans 7:24-25).

Praise God that we have a Rescuer in Jesus. He has rescued us, He is rescuing us, and He will finally and fully rescue us in glory.

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Definition

Rescue (or deliverance) is God saving people from danger, freeing them from sin, evil, and judgment, both now and forever through Jesus.

Reflection Questions

Who or what were some of the threats that God rescued you from?

Who is someone who you know who is enslaved in their sin in the domain of darkness? Pray that God would deliver them through the gospel.

Gospel Response

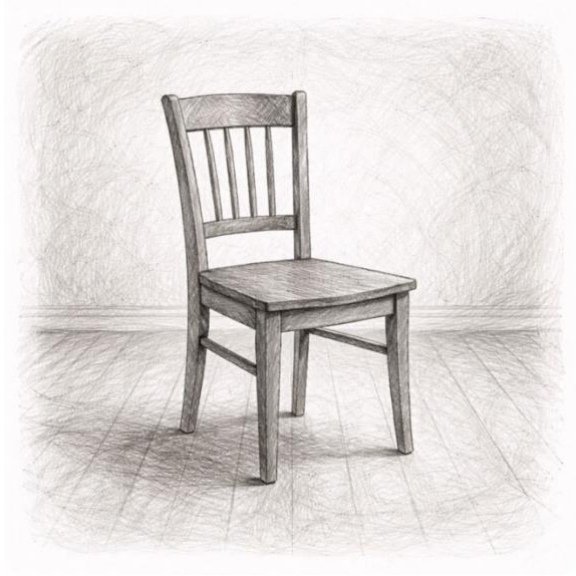
Light a candle, firepit or fireplace today. As you look at the flames, visualize the burning house you were trapped in from which Jesus rescued you. Give thanks that though you were without hope He broke through and delivered you.

Prayer

My Deliverer,

Thank you for pulling me out of the flames, for delivering me from the domain of darkness. You are my rescuer. Help me to rely on you even today amid temptation to deliver me from evil. Protect me and preserve me as I cling to you.

Amen



DAY 25

FAITH

*“Therefore, since we have been justified by faith,
we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ.”*

Romans 5:1

Greek: πίστις (*pistis*) – “faith, trust, confidence, reliance”

Have you ever felt completely out of control? Several years ago I attended a summer camp with the students from our church and found myself one afternoon on the high ropes course leading to a zipline. To get to the zipline you had to climb up a rock wall and navigate the high ropes course. These were fun but not too challenging so as I was getting hooked-in to the zipline, I asked the ropes guide, “How can I make this more exciting?” He answered simply, “Jump off the landing without holding onto the rope.”

The rope was securely fastened to my harness, along with a back-up safety rope. Holding on to the rope really does nothing except make you feel like you are keeping yourself safe. But despite telling myself this repeatedly and trying my best to take the challenge when I jumped my hands instinctually grabbed the rope as I felt myself falling in the initial drop-off. It was too hard to let go and just trust.

The word for “faith” and its verb form “believe” are used almost five

hundred times in the New Testament. It means having a full confidence or reliance. It means sitting in a chair because you are sure it will hold you. Normally when we sit down, we don't even think about it. We implicitly trust the chair will support us. We do nothing but rest our weight in the chair. Faith is resting completely in Christ, trusting that the work of Jesus on the cross can bear the weight of our sin.

Faith lies at the center of the gospel. Faith has always been God's chosen instrument of salvation. Hebrews 11 walks through redemption history declaring that the spiritual giants of old all lived "by faith." The author of Hebrews powerfully summarizes the importance of faith like this,

"Without faith it is impossible to please him, for whoever would draw near to God must believe that he exists and that he rewards those who seek him." (Hebrews 11:6)

The gospel requires a faith response to save. The good news is that it *only* requires a faith response. The gospel most certainly points to the work of Jesus on the cross for sinners, but one must respond to the gospel by trusting that it is enough to save, by trusting that the rope can carry you, by trusting that the chair can hold you.

The doctrine of salvation through faith alone, or as the Reformers called it *Sola fide*, is replete throughout God's Word. To name just a few:

"For we hold that one is justified by faith apart from works of the law." (Romans 3:28)

"Therefore, since we have been justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ." (Romans 5:1)

"...a person is not justified by works of the law but through faith in Jesus Christ" (Galatians 2:16)

"For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast." (Ephesians 2:8-9)

As much as it comes unnaturally to us, there is nothing we can do to save ourselves. We are pathetically inadequate, but the cross is enough. The good news of Jesus is that all we need do is call "on the name of the Lord" and we "will be saved" (Romans 10:13). Put simply,

"For with the heart one believes and is justified, and with the mouth one confesses and is saved. For the Scripture says, 'Everyone who believes in him will not be put to shame.'" (Romans 10:10-11)

Are you relying on Christ alone for your salvation? Are you trusting in His work on the cross to save you, rescue you, justify you, and make an atonement

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for your sin? In our flesh we seek to hold onto other things like our good works or our religious activity, but these things are never enough. There is nothing we can add to the righteousness provided by God through faith. Scripture states, “[Abraham] believed the Lord, and he counted it to him as righteousness” (Genesis 15:6; see also Galatians 3:6; Romans 4:9, 22). It is only faith that can save. It is the one who “believes in him” that will never perish (John 3:16).

Have you sat in the chair? Have you trusted Jesus completely? We have seen the wonders of the gospel and of God’s salvation through Jesus in the previous pages. Have you put your faith in Him? It is as simple as believing “in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved” (Acts 16:31). Take the step, trust the chair.

Definition

Faith is trusting Jesus alone to save you and relying on Him instead of yourself.

Reflection Questions

In what areas of your life might you be relying on "good works" or religious activities instead of faith alone?

What steps can you take today to deepen your reliance on God, especially if doubt or self-reliance creeps in?

Gospel Response

When you sit in a chair today, give thanks that God is holding you. Rejoice that Jesus can bear the weight of your sin as you trust in Him.

Prayer

God,

Thank you for saving me. Thank you for opening my eyes to trust in you alone for the forgiveness of sin. Help me to walk by faith. Forgive me for self-reliance and self-righteousness. Remove any doubts from my heart and mind. Help me to trust you completely as my solid rock. May I rest confidently in you today.

Amen.



DAY 26

REPENTANCE

*“The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand;
repent and believe in the gospel.”*

Mark 1:15

Greek: μετάνοια (*metanoia*) – “a change of mind, repentance”

Few things bother me as much as making a wrong turn, especially if it takes me way out of the way! A few years ago we were travelling to South Haven, Michigan, a beautifully kept secret on the east coast of Lake Michigan (with sandy beaches and no salt or sharks, by the way!) and I made a wrong turn. Of course it was my Google Maps fault; at least that is my story. Immediately, the app rerouted me to turn around a few miles down the road, another 10 minutes instantly added to the already several hour journey. As I got off the exit and then merged back on the highway going the opposite direction my boys in the backseat cried out, “What’s going on? Did we make a wrong turn?!” It is humbling to make a mistake, to go the wrong way, but the best thing you can do in that moment is admit it and turn around to get back on the right road. The gospel necessitates this same attitude in order to be received.

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For godly grief produces a repentance that leads to salvation without regret, whereas worldly grief produces death.” (2 Corinthians 7:10)

We must come to the end of ourselves, repent of our sin and turn to God. Faith, which we just discussed yesterday, is trusting in Christ alone, *turning to* Him for salvation. Repentance is the other side of the coin. Repentance is *turning from* sin, self, and Satan. The word means to change one’s thinking, to reconsider, or to reverse, or make a 180-degree turn. Scripture teaches that saving faith is evident in that it turns away from worldly things and bears the fruit of righteousness.

John the Baptist prepared the way for this gospel, calling the Pharisees to “bear fruits in keeping with repentance” (Luke 3:8, Matthew 3:8). Then Jesus appeared preaching a gospel of repentance: “repent and believe in the gospel” (Mark 1:15, see also Matthew 4:17). This idea is repeated throughout the ministry of Jesus who said,

“I have not come to call the righteous but sinners to repentance.” (Luke 5:32)

“Just so, I tell you, there will be more joy in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who need no repentance.” (Luke 15:7)

“No, I tell you; but unless you repent, you will all likewise perish.” (Luke 13:3)

Jesus reserved some of His harshest words for those who refused to repent (Matthew 11:20; Luke 10:13; 11:32). He also sent out His disciples with this same message: “they went out and proclaimed that people should repent” (Mark 6:12). The message is clear, as we have seen, faith alone saves but saving faith repents. As James puts it, “faith without works is dead” (James 2:17, 26). Real faith produces real fruit. This repentance looks like turning from self and sin and turning to the Savior.

“If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross daily and follow me.” (Luke 9:23)

This same message of repentance is repeated by the apostles in Acts, at the founding of the church:

“And Peter said to them, ‘Repent and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins, and you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit.’” (Acts 2:38)

“Repent therefore, and turn back, that your sins may be blotted out.” (Acts 3:19)

Responding to the gospel involves faith that is marked by repentance. Have

you repented of your sin? Have you come to the end of yourself and turned completely to Christ. Have you made the most important U-turn anyone could ever make? Repentance also means turning from self-righteousness, the idea that “I am good enough,” and embracing complete dependence on God. Only when we turn from our sin and turn to Christ, believing the gospel can we experience forgiveness. Jesus, after his resurrection, proclaimed that this was the plan from the very beginning, that the Messiah would come, suffer and die then rise from the dead so that “repentance for the forgiveness of sins should be proclaimed in his name to all nations” (Luke 24:46-47). The gospel is the good news that those who repent of their sin and receive the Savior by faith will be saved.

Definition

Repentance is the turning of a sinner away from sin and toward God, involving a change of mind, heart, and direction of life.

Reflection Questions

In what areas of your life are you experiencing a godly sorrow that leads to repentance? How can you foster godly sorrow for your sin? (See 2 Corinthians 7:10)

How does the gospel of repentance of sin differ from the easy believism that is prominent among many Christians today?

Gospel Response

As you drive or ride around today think of the U-turn that God calls everyone to make, turning from their sin and to the Savior, for the forgiveness of their sins.

Prayer

God,

*I praise you that you are a merciful God, slow to anger and abounding in lovingkindness. Thank you for your patience with me. Convict me of sin in my life and may I, today, bear fruit in keeping with repentance. When I find myself today walking the wrong direction in my thoughts, attitudes, words, or deeds, strengthen me to turn around and to run to you. Thank you for always meeting me there on the path of repentance with love and grace in your eyes.
Amen.*



DAY 27

SANCTIFICATION

“And such were some of you. But you were washed, you were sanctified, you were justified in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ and by the Spirit of our God.”

1 Corinthians 6:11

Greek: ἁγιασμός (*hagiasmos*) – “holiness, consecration, purification, sanctification, to be set apart, made holy and righteous.”

I remember stepping onto the track at Liberty University on my first day of practice. I had been recruited to run the 400 meter and was excited to compete as a collegiate athlete. Not long after we were given our “gear.” Warm-ups, shoes, practice shirts, and a uniform. It was official, I was a “Liberty Flame.” I still have that warm-up jacket. Putting it on did and still does feel special. It became part of my identity, and it was a sign of belonging to the team. Though I didn’t always perform at the level I wished and especially in those early days I felt like the new kid on the block, the jacket told a different story. I was a member of the team. I had not run one race yet, but I was given the jacket.

When we come to Christ by faith He clothes us in His righteousness. God, by the blood of Christ and the cleansing power of the Holy Spirit sanctifies us. That means He makes us holy. He covers our sin. He sets us apart unto Himself. This is our new identity in Christ at the point of salvation. Paul writing to the

church of Corinth acknowledges this reality,

“To the church of God that is in Corinth, to those sanctified in Christ Jesus, called to be saints together with all those who in every place call upon the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, both their Lord and ours” (1 Corinthians 1:2)

The words “sanctified” and “saints” both come from the Greek root word that means “holy.” It means to be sacred, consecrated, poor, and blameless. The only reason this can be a reality is because we are “in Christ Jesus.” Our new identity has been applied to us through Jesus. We have literally “put on Christ” like a jacket, or better yet a robe of righteousness (Galatians 3:27). Like one of my favorite hymns to sing says,

*Dressed in His righteousness alone
Faultless stand before the throne*

“My Hope is Built on Nothing Less”
—Edward Mote

If you grew up in the church you probably think of sanctification as the progressive work of God in the life of the Christian to make him or her more holy. In theology this is called *progressive sanctification*. Most of the Scriptures that use the term “sanctify” are referring to this work of the Spirit that is ongoing in believers. But in several places, the New Testament uses this term to describe a work done in the believer at that moment of salvation. Closely akin to justification, being declared righteous, and regeneration, being brought to new life, sanctification is the setting apart of the believer from sin unto holiness. This is a *definitive* or *positional* sanctification that comes to us through our identity in Christ. When we are called to Christ we are made holy people in Christ (1 Peter 2:9). Believers have already been sanctified by the blood of Christ.

“And by that will we have been sanctified through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for all.” (Hebrews 10:10)

The author of Hebrews points out that the work of Christ on the cross positionally sanctified us. Now this work is not finished and won’t be until glorification, the final chapter of our salvation which will be discussed later, but Scripture is clear that we, through Jesus, have already been made perfect. Notice how both aspects of sanctification are illustrated just a few verses later in Hebrews:

*“For by a single offering he has perfected for all time those who are being sanctified.”
(Hebrews 10:14)*

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We “have been perfected” and yet we “are being sanctified.” In Christ, God the Father sees us as holy. And yet, as we war with the flesh in this life, the Holy Spirit sanctifies us progressively (1 Peter 1:2; Romans 15:16). But at salvation our identity has changed. We are now called saints, literally “holy ones.” We are Christ’s workmanship and a new creation (Ephesians 2:10; 2 Corinthians 5:17). We were *sinners*, but now we are called *saints*. As Paul calls the Corinthian believers unto holiness he reminds them of who they used to be and who they are now in Christ,

“And such were some of you. But you were washed, you were sanctified, you were justified in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ and by the Spirit of our God.”
(1 Corinthians 6:11)

If you are in Christ, the gospel teaches that you *are* holy (See also 1 Corinthians 1:30). You have been set apart by the Holy Spirit. You have a new identity and garment of holiness that covers all of your sin. This work of God in us continues as we seek to “be holy as [God] is holy” but ultimately our sanctification begins and ends with God, the One who calls us holy (1 Peter 1:16). Sanctification, like our salvation, is a work of God’s grace.

“And now I commend you to God and to the word of his grace, which is able to build you up and to give you the inheritance among all those who are sanctified.” (Acts 20:32)

Definition

Sanctification means God has set you apart as holy and His, and now He is making you more like Jesus.

Reflection Questions

What is the difference between positional and progressive sanctification? How do you think understanding your identity in Christ as a saint (holy one) is instrumental in helping us become more like Jesus?

What things in your life are unholy? Commit today to “take off” these garments of the sin and flesh and to “put on” the Lord Jesus Christ.

Gospel Response

When you put on clothes today remember the holiness of Christ in which you have already been clothed. Give thanks that your identity is not based on your performance.

Prayer

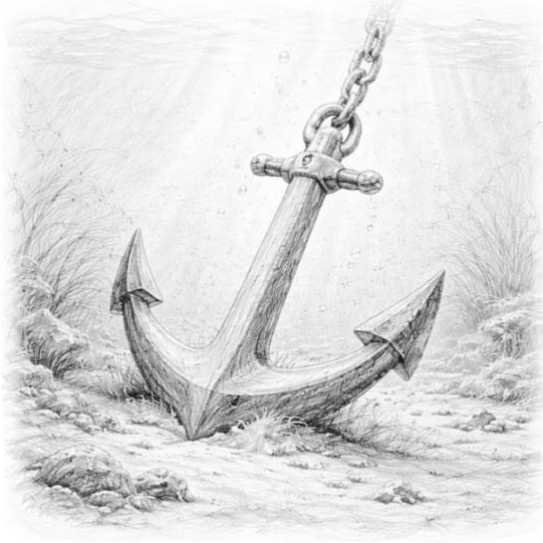
God,

Thank you for sanctifying me. I am trusting that you, who began a good work in me, will bring it to completion. May I live out my new status as a saint, a holy child of God. May I remember that my position before you has been established through the work of Jesus and by the power of the Holy Spirit. Help me to live as who I am and who you have called me. Sanctify me today in your truth (John 17:17).

Amen.

PART V
OUR FUTURE

How the gospel awakens a confident hope for what is coming.



DAY 28

HOPE

*“We have this as a sure and steadfast anchor of the soul,
a hope that enters into the inner place behind the curtain.”
Hebrews 6:19*

Greek: ἐλπίς (*elpis*) – “hope, confident expectation, trust”

Viktor Frankl, the renowned Austrian psychiatrist and Holocaust survivor, endured unimaginable horrors in Nazi concentration camps, including Auschwitz, where he lost his wife, mother, and brother. Amid the darkness of starvation, brutality, and despair, Frankl discovered a profound truth: that even when everything is stripped away, humans retain the freedom to choose their attitude and either find meaning in suffering or despair. Consider his piercing words: "The sudden loss of hope and courage can have a deadly effect." Hopelessness destroys life but hope can be an anchor through any storm.

The gospel brings incomparable hope. To receive the gospel is to have a new hope. The Apostle Peter described it this way,

“Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead.” (1 Peter 1:3)

Paul says, likewise, that followers of Jesus are one body, indwelled by one

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Spirit and “called to the one hope” (Ephesians 4:4). Christians are to be defined by their hope. This biblical term means a confident expectation, a confident trust. It is not a “wish.” It is a firm assurance. It is an anchor for the heart and soul.

“We have this as a sure and steadfast anchor of the soul, a hope that enters into the inner place behind the curtain.” (Hebrews 6:19)

An anchor secures a ship so that it does not drift as it floats in water. Its heavy weight and often the design of its shape make it ideal for securing the vessel even in turbulent waters. The gospel is an anchor. Christians stand on a sure foundation. As the old song says,

*My hope is built on nothing less
than Jesus' blood and righteousness;
I dare not trust the sweetest frame,
but wholly lean on Jesus' name.*

*On Christ, the solid Rock, I stand:
all other ground is sinking sand;
all other ground is sinking sand.*

“My Hope is Built on Nothing Less”
—Edward Mote

This solid rock is Jesus, who is our hope. He is the rock to which our anchor holds through the gospel. The power of the cross is that it has definitively dealt with our sin and delivered eternal life to those who believe. This faith is the “stable and steadfast” anchor, “the hope of the gospel” (Colossians 1:23). Has the gospel given you a confident hope? Is your hope in Christ? Do you know the “hope to which he has called you” (Ephesians 1:18)?

What is hope? It is a confident expectation of future good. Hope means that dawn is approaching to cast away the darkness. The gospel primarily concerns eternal reconciliation to God, forever with Him. Eternal life is the hope of the believer. We are “waiting for our blessed hope, the appearing of the glory of our great God and Savior Jesus Christ” (Titus 2:13). The good news of Jesus promises that those who believe “become heirs according to the hope of eternal life” (Titus 3:7). It is a “glorious inheritance” and “imperishable, undefiled, and unfading, kept in heaven for you” (Ephesians 1:18; 1 Peter 1:4). Christians possess a “hope of glory” in Christ, and it is “an eternal weight of glory beyond all comparison” (Colossians 1:27; 2 Corinthians 4:17). This inheritance belongs to every Christian. The gospel gives hope forever. It is an anchor that holds through any storm of this life.

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“May the God of hope fill you with all joy and peace in believing, so that by the power of the Holy Spirit you may abound in hope.” (Romans 15:13)

Definition

Hope is the confident expectation of future good, grounded in the promises of God and secured by the finished work of Jesus Christ.

Reflection Questions

How does our response to trials and suffering reveal where our hope lies? Are you clinging to the gospel of hope?

Read Ephesians 1:11-21. What is the role of hope in the Christian life? How are faith and hope related?

Gospel Response

Whenever you see a rock today think of Jesus, the solid rock to whom you are anchored. Remember that you are safe and secure, kept by God, in the storms of life.

Prayer

God,

Thank you for saving me and giving me a new hope. Help me to keep eternity on my mind, to remember that good is coming because of Jesus. May I cling to hope and may it abound in my soul today. May it be evident to others and may I be ready to give a reason for the hope that is in me (1 Peter 3:15). Help me to remain in you today, to be firmly anchored to Christ. Amen.



DAY 29

GLORIFICATION

“So is it with the resurrection of the dead. What is sown is perishable; what is raised is imperishable. It is sown in dishonor; it is raised in glory. It is sown in weakness; it is raised in power.”

1 Corinthians 15:42-43

Greek: δόξα (*doxa*) – “glory, dignity, glorious, honor”

There are few things as valuable as a diamond. As the hardest known natural material, diamonds are highly resistant to scratching. They are also resistant to heat, light, and most chemicals. And of course, they are beautiful; they maintain their polish and brilliance for decades. Not every diamond is perfect; if you have ever shopped for a diamond, you know this. Each diamond is graded on a scale of clarity. The highest grade is flawless. Flawless diamonds have a perfect purity, completely without blemish. This illustrates the reality that the gospel promises that every believer will one day be made perfect, beautiful, and flawless.

This is the final fulfillment of our salvation, and the Bible calls it “glorious.” We will become like Jesus, in all His glory. This reality is as certain as our justification.

“For those whom he foreknew he also predestined to be conformed to the image of his Son, in order that he might be the firstborn among many brothers. And those whom he predestined he also called, and those whom he called he also justified, and those whom he

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justified he also glorified.” (Romans 8:29–30)

Glorification is the completion of the work that God began in us at salvation. Paul says this will occur “at the day of Jesus Christ” (Philippians 1:6). Jesus is coming back to transform His people into His likeness. We will become like Him. Glorification will be realized at the second coming. We will on that day “appear with him in glory” (Colossians 3:4). We will be called home and transformed forever.

“But our citizenship is in heaven, and from it we await a Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ, who will transform our lowly body to be like his glorious body, by the power that enables him even to subject all things to himself.” (Philippians 3:20–21)

Glorification is the complete fulfillment of our salvation. We have already been adopted, justified, redeemed, atoned for, and rescued. Our salvation is real and present, but it is not yet complete. We still struggle with the ongoing presence of sin in our flesh and in a fallen world. This hope of glorification gives us hope on the darkest days. On the days of suffering, temptation, pain, and loss, we remember that one day God will make “all things new” (Revelation 21:5). We know how the story ends. Everything will be finally changed forever.

So we do not lose heart. Though our outer self is wasting away, our inner self is being renewed day by day. For this light momentary affliction is preparing for us an eternal weight of glory beyond all comparison (2 Corinthians 4:16-17)

Our salvation fulfilled will be so perfect that all the sufferings of this life will fade into the distant past. They are “not worth comparing with the glory that is to be revealed to us” (Romans 8:18). When we look into the eyes of our Savior, when He returns for us, we will be forever, perfectly, made like Him.

*“Beloved, we are God’s children now, and what we will be has not yet appeared; but we know that when he appears we shall be like him, because we shall see him as he is.”
(1 John 3:2)*

The work of the gospel will finally be complete when we stand face to face with our Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ.

To the praise of His glorious grace.

Definition

Glorification is the wonderful moment when Jesus returns and God instantly makes every Christian completely perfect, like Jesus Himself, with no more sin, pain, weakness, or death, so we can live with Him forever in glory.

Reflection Questions

What are some of the hardships, temptations, and realities of living in this fallen world that you eagerly anticipate leaving behind when you enter glory?

How should our identity as citizens of heaven change how we live in this life?
(See Philippians 3:20-21)

Gospel Response

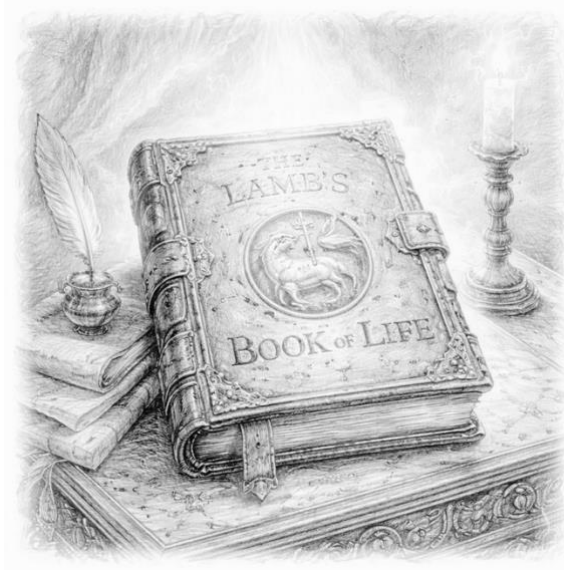
When you see jewelry today, think of the precious and flawless glorification we will experience at the coming of Christ.

Prayer

Glorious God,

Thank you for the promise of glory. Help me to expectantly wait and anticipate this transformation into the image of Christ. When this world gets hard, may I remember the end of this story, being made like you forever. Thank you, that you will finish the work of salvation that you have begun in me on that day.

Amen.



DAY 30

ELECTION

“Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who has blessed us in Christ with every spiritual blessing in the heavenly places, even as he chose us in him before the foundation of the world, that we should be holy and blameless before him.”

Ephesians 1:3-4

Greek: ἐκλέγομαι (*eklegomai*) – “to choose, to pick out, to elect”

What is your favorite story? Maybe it is a novel or book like *The Lord of the Rings*, *Dune*, or *To Kill a Mockingbird*. Or maybe you are more interested in movies and you love *Star Wars* or *Avengers*, or one of my personal favorites: M. Night Shyamalan’s *The Village*. You should check it out; it is an epic story! Most of us are inspired by true stories of people who won against the odds and accomplished great things or inspired movements through sacrifice in the face of adversity. We all love stories! Most stories follow a similar pattern; they establish the setting and characters, introduce a conflict, then the action rises to a climax, and last the story leads towards a final resolution. Every great story has a moment of darkness and then the light breaks through. Mufasa sacrifices himself for Simba, then Simba ascends to the throne as *The Lion King*. God is

the Author of the great story of redemption. The gospel is the best story ever told.

We could even say that the gospel is the true story that all others seek to imitate. As J.R.R. Tolkien contended with his skeptical friend, C.S. Lewis, the story of Jesus is “true myth.” It is the ultimate story of meaning, love, and self-sacrifice. The cross is the greatest climactic moment in human history. As we have worked through the different threads of this story, the reality of the gospel is that Jesus is the Author (Hebrews 12:2).

In the book of Revelation we learn that this story of redemption was written before the foundations of the world in a book!

“Everyone whose name has not been written from the foundation of the world in the book of life of the Lamb who was slain” (Revelation 13:8; See also 17:8).

To be written in this book is to be chosen and secure, sealed for redemption. This is the beginning and the end of the gospel story, which is why we arrive here last. The gospel will be fulfilled in glorification and heaven for the redeemed, but this good news of salvation was promised in eternity past.

“...even as he chose us in him before the foundation of the world, that we should be holy and blameless before him. In love he predestined us for adoption to himself as sons through Jesus Christ, according to the purpose of his will, to the praise of his glorious grace, with which he has blessed us in the Beloved.” (Ephesians 1:4-6)

Few doctrines in recent times draw as much lively debate among Christians as the sovereignty of God, election, and predestination. “What about my free will?” One will say. Some argue that God’s election is conditioned upon his foreknowledge, He elects or chooses the redeemed based upon their future faith response, as Scripture states,

“To those who are elect exiles...according to the foreknowledge of God” (1 Peter 1:1-2)

“For those whom he foreknew he also predestined to be conformed to the image of his Son, in order that he might be the firstborn among many brothers. And those whom he predestined he also called, and those whom he called he also justified, and those whom he justified he also glorified...” (Romans 8:29-30)

Others respond that God chooses us unconditionally.

*“[He] saved us and called us to a holy calling, not because of our works but because of his own purpose and grace, which he gave us in Christ Jesus before the ages began.”
(2 Timothy 1:9)*

“He chose us in him before the foundation of the world...according to the purpose of his

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will” (Ephesians 1:4-6).

Regardless of which side of the theological spectrum we fall on, the reality taught in Scripture is that God knows those who are His. He knows who He will save and redeem and He will receive all the glory for redemption. The universe that God created is one which glorifies Him ultimately and magnifies His character perfectly. And at the center of His glory is the gospel, the good news of Jesus. The cross was not plan B. It was the history God wanted to write for His glory.

“This Jesus, delivered up according to the definite plan and foreknowledge of God, you crucified and killed by the hands of lawless men. God raised him up, loosing the pangs of death, because it was not possible for him to be held by it.” (Acts 2:23-24)

God writes the best stories. And if you are in Christ, if you have received the gospel, you know how the story ends. You can know that you are safe and secure, and all things will work out for good in your life.

“And we know that for those who love God all things work together for good, for those who are called according to his purpose.” (Romans 8:28)

Have you turned from your sin and by faith received the Lord Jesus Christ for salvation? If you have, you are chosen by God to declare this gospel, to proclaim to all until the trumpet sounds.

“You are a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for his own possession, that you may proclaim the excellencies of him who called you out of darkness into his marvelous light.” (1 Peter 2:9)

Definition

Election is God’s choice, made before the world began, to save people through Jesus, not because they earned it or were better than others, but because of His love and mercy.

Reflection Questions

How does knowing that God is in control and is the Author of our story give us peace in the midst of the storms of life?

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In Revelation 3:5, we're told that those in Christ cannot have their names erased from the Lamb's Book of Life. How does that truth strengthen your assurance?

Gospel Response

When you see a book today, remember that if you have believed in Christ your name is written safe and secure as the redeemed of the Lord! Give thanks that you belong to the Lamb.

Prayer

Sovereign God,

Thank you that you get glory through redemption. Thank you for saving me according to your mercy and grace. May I boldly proclaim the gospel of Jesus Christ, declaring the praises of the one who called me out of darkness and into your marvelous light. You alone deserve the glory and honor and praise in my life. Thank you for the good news of Jesus, my Savior and Lord. Amen.



EPILOGUE

“And he said to them, “Go into all the world and proclaim the gospel to the whole creation.”

Mark 16:15

The gospel is beautiful. It shines through in each of the words we have explored in the last thirty days. As we look at the light of the gospel of the glory of Christ it must elicit a dual response from us: **worship and witness**.

Like the lame man who was healed (Acts 3), we must leap for joy at the wonder of the gospel that saves. When we see that a loving, merciful, gracious God has saved, redeemed, justified, and rescued us through Jesus, we shout for joy! We praise the Lord! We have been adopted into His family. We have been reconciled to God forever, and we have hope and peace everlasting! Let us worship the Lord!

“Yet I will rejoice in the LORD; I will take joy in the God of my salvation.”

Habakkuk 3:18

Secondly, we must bear witness to this good news. We must steward this marvelous gift we have received by sharing it with others! Furthermore, when the Spirit indwells us, He empowers us for a mission and a ministry. As believers saved through the gospel, we have been called to be witnesses.

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“But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth.”
Acts 1:8

To whom will you witness? Who has God placed in your life who needs to hear the gospel of Jesus Christ? We should labor diligently in this work of proclaiming the gospel we have received. As the Apostle Paul stated,

“I have become all things to all people, that by all means I might save some. I do it all for the sake of the gospel, that I may share with them in its blessings.”
1 Corinthians 9:22-23

As we join God on mission to “proclaim the gospel to the whole creation” we “hasten his coming” (Mark 16:15; 2 Peter 3:12). Our hope is right around the corner. The gospel must go forth until the whole world hears, and then the trumpet of the Lord will sound. Go and share the gospel, the greatest news in history.

“And this gospel of the kingdom will be proclaimed throughout the whole world as a testimony to all nations, and then the end will come.” Matthew 24:13-14

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Phil Leineweber is a pastor, teacher, and author passionate about making God's Word and the gospel clear and practical. He holds a Bachelor of Science and Master of Arts in Religion and a Master of Divinity from Liberty University, as well as a Doctor of Ministry in Applied Theology from The Southern Baptist Theological Seminary. He has served for over 10 years in pastoral ministry and most recently as Executive Pastor of Ministries at Berean Baptist Church in Mansfield, Ohio and Lead Pastor of Faith Church in Crestline, Ohio. He is husband to Sarah and father to three sons: Andrew, Asher, and Jackson. Phil writes and shares biblical reflections through his website (philwithgrace.com)

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